When the Music Starts (Again)

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Not Rated

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

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Non-Graphic Violence, maybe smut?, Love, Cop Adora, Smitten Lesbians, Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Canon Lesbian Relationship

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Part 3 of With You

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by the_things_nobody_asks

Summary

The final part to the series "With You" (The end to "When the Music Stops"). The first chapter is Adora's POV where we last left off.

Notes

So...are y'all ready for this shiz? It's about to go down.

See the end of the work for more notes

Thank God for Douchy Cars

"What do you mean there was nothing useful in the car?" She tries not to let the sentence send her reeling, but she'd been so hopeful...

"I mean there was nothing. We checked everywhere. No hair, no prints -the car was clean."

That didn't make sense. Those men didn't exactly seem to be terribly careful. They weren't wearing gloves. If they were really in charge of doing this Hordak's dirty work, then their vehicle should show signs of it, even if they were small. They had to be missing something.

"Ether."

Adora was pulled from her thoughts. "Yeah."

"I'm tired of crawlin' around on my hands and knees for the day, so I'm just going to take some case notes and then I'll probably call it a day. Feel free to check it out yourself."

"I might." She definitely would. Something wasn't right. It was kind of nice that Thornbrush was still letting Adora in on this case even though she didn't have to. Most people wouldn't. Maybe she could just sense that it meant something to Adora.

She pulls up to the precinct about 20 minutes later and walks through the back -to the forensics lab. Entrapta was sitting at the computer, thoroughly invested in something, muttering to herself quietly under her breath. Although she didn't look like much, the girl was a genius. While she was in college, Adora noticed Entrapta seemed to be having trouble holding down a job -her people skills weren't the best. Where she excelled was any and all things data and technology-related. Coding, data inscription, hacking for information, GPS locating, robotics, the list went on. She even built her own crazy gadgets.

The forensics department when she first joined the force was absolutely lackluster if not inefficient, and Adora knew this would be a perfect job for Entrapta. She convinced Angella to give her a shot. On her first day, she absentmindedly solved a murder case that had been cold for months by running a simulation on a laptop she made herself. It was crazy. Angella hired her on the spot. Entrapta didn't have the best people skills insofar as social convention was concerned, but she was loyal. Adora could always count on her, and she would definitely need her expertise to put this puzzle together, to find the missing pieces to her puzzles.

"Hey Entrapta."

Without breaking eye contact with the screen, she held up a finger, continuing to mutter to herself. Adora waited until, finally. "Hi!"

"I need your help. Are you doing anything important right now?"

"I'm always doing something important." As literal as ever. "Right now I'm working on making a flame-retardant polymer."

Adora smiled, "Let me clarify: are you working on anything for a case right now?"

"Just waiting on some blood panels and running a few statistical analyses."

Adora stared at her. "So…"

"So no! I'm not really doing anything. Why? What do you need?"

"We've got a vehicle here that I'd like you to check for...well...anything. Any hair, dust, prints, threads -literally any shred of evidence. The Feds brought it in and did a sweep, but I think they had to have missed something and you're the best person I can think of to look for things that don't want to be found."

“Gee, that’s nice of you to say. I am passionate about the general concept of discovery.”

“So, whatdyou say? Will you help me look?”

“Sure! Sounds fun!”

They make their way through the side door to a covered garage area where all the compounded vehicles are. Entrapta knees next to her little tool box and pulls out a bunch of bags full of equipment. She dons gloves and a headlamp-looking light. She seems to get irritated with Adora for looking over her shoulder, so she backs off and starts trying to put the pieces together again. Huntara had said that the contact had no new information. That was bullshit. It had to be bullshit. Maybe Adora could try…

She looked at Entrapta who was fast at work doing...whatever it was that she was doing. If there was anything to be found, Entrapta would find it. The blonde scrolls through her photos until she finds what she’s looking for -a picture of the informant and a phone number. She dials.

It rings once. Five times. Of course they wouldn’t pick up. Ope. It sounds like they did pick up, but nobody is saying anything. “Hello?”

“Speaking.” Yes, but WHO is speaking? The voice on the other line is both scratchy and breathy at the same time.

“Is this Double Trouble?”

“Honey I can be anybody you want me to be, for a price.” And with that, her suspicions were confirmed. This person had skin in the game. They were in it for profit -probably playing them all like a violin.

“My name is Adora, I’m a detective working with the DEA and FBI. I believe you spoke to my colleague not but an hour ago.”

“Yes.” This person was cautious, calculated. Adora would have to be that way too.

“I’m hoping you can answer some questions for me.”

“I’m afraid I’ve already told your little friends everything I know.” At least it was the answer she was expecting.

“Well then I’d appreciate it if you could tell me again, please.” Keep your cool. Be polite, but firm.

“Now don’t tell me you don’t believe your own partners. How scandalous.” There was a dry giggle through the phone. “Clever girl. Don’t trust anyone -that’s the truth.”

“I BELIEVE they’re under the impression that you didn’t know any more specifics about Hordak’s whereabouts, or his dealings with the strip club, and I think you and I both know that’s a crock of shit.”

“My, my. The rookie does swear. And here I thought you would be shaking in your boots.” Adora could practically feel the sarcasm dripping through the phone. Wait, rookie? I never said I was green.

“Look, I know you’re getting a nice chunk of change for cooperating, but I can sweeten the deal if that’s what you want.”

“Using who’s wallet?”

“It’s not about the money -”

“Darling, it’s ALWAYS about the money.”

Adora was starting to lose her cool. This wasn’t a goddamn game. This was people’s lives -men, women, and children. She set her jaw and spoke evenly into the phone. “I WILL be exposing this operation. I WILL bring Hordak in and he will be held responsible for his crimes against this city and humanity at large -him and everyone else participating. Unless you wanna be grouped in with

that load of garbage, I suggest you talk. I can guarantee that you will be absolved of whatever part we both know you play in his game when the curtain is gone."

Silence. Then, finally, a breath."Very good, detective. I have chills. I have to say, you give a pretty convincing performance, but alas, you don't even know what you think you know." That struck Adora as eerie.

"I will if you tell me."

"Perhaps. That also requires you trust me." Hah! Not a chance. "So...do you trust me?"

"Not half as far as I can throw you." She paused. "What do you say?"

"I'd say I like your spirit, Detective. "

"Enough to talk?"

"Enough to tell you that I like your spirit."

Adora tightened her grip on the phone, almost as if it would give her any more of an edge. "I'm only going to offer you this out one time, right now. That's it."

"Or?"

"Or the next time we talk, you'll probably be in handcuffs."

"Mmm, don't threaten me with a good time, Miss Ether." The purr of their voice made Adora uncomfortable."Tempting, indeed."

She waits. Silence for a moment. "What I'll say is this: if you want to put a stop to it all and save your precious kitten, you're going to have to go back to where you first came into all of this mess - where it all stopped and started." Click.

Adora put the phone down slowly. Kitten? Catra? They know about Catra? Not only that, they know I have history with Catra. That's worse. And they called me 'Ether'. They knew my last name. I didn't tell them my last name. They knew I'm new to the case -called me a rookie. She swallowed. They had somebody on the inside. Somebody was informing the informant. Shit.

"Adora, this car was cleaned."

Entrapta's voice pulled her from her downward spiral, but only for a moment, and only to confirm her suspicions. "Cleaned how?"

"I mean, like professionally. Somebody has sterilized the steering wheel and seats. Even the floorboards appear to have been vacuumed and wiped. I can't get anything other than an estimation of how tall the frequent driver was." Shit. Shit. Shit.

Adora wiped a hand anxiously over her hair. "How?"

"Based on the automatic seat placement, I estimate they were about six-one. Probably male." Sounds about right for the guys who tried to kidnap them...but goddammit. Nothing else? Really? Somebody had to have snuck in before Huntara's people got there. And nobody noticed?

Bzzzz. King was calling her. "Hello?" What now?

"Ether, some shit went down at the club. Two people are dead."

"What?" Jesus, could this get any worse?

"Thornbrush told me to tell you to come down here. I'm not sure why. Don't get me wrong, Ether, you've got eyes like a hawk and I know you're invested in this case, but I think you might as well stay home. There's not much you can do right now."

"I'm not at home. I'll be right there."

"Oh. Well, you really don't need to come down here, Ether. It's not pretty." He sighed heavily. "This just keeps getting messier and

messier. We pissed some people off, that's for damn sure."

"Who were they? Do we know?"

"One of them is the owner, Robert. He was shot." Damn. "The other is a middle-aged woman, blonde. Looks like she was strangled." An image of the older waitress flashed in her mind -the woman who knew Catra. She really hoped it was a different person. Adora inhaled sharply. "Somebody called 911 because they heard the gunshot, but both were dead at the scene. The woman had an envelope in her pocket labelled 'Catra'. Isn't that the girl with you?" Goddammit.

"Yeah."

"I hate to say it, but she may not be an innocent victim in all of this like we thought. Keep an eye on her. Make sure she doesn't go anywhere."

Adora didn't know what to say. Her mind was still chewing on what the informant said. Back to where you came into all of this mess. Where it all stopped and started. Stopped and started at the same time? Or same place? What did that mean? Where it all stopped and started...Where YOU came into all of this mess...stopped...and started…Diego? Diego was a dead end. He gave them nothing and nobody else directly involved talked. Except technically this one irritatingly subversive -and extortive - informant who hasn't really given anybody any good information. She probably shouldn't even be giving second thought to that entire conversation. But...still it was all they had. The only person who was willing to say a word against Diego was the old neighbor who called in the first place, and she...she…

She made him angry. He'd become unhinged when he saw her there. So furious -and the way he laughed. 'She finally did it', he said -as if she'd been threatening to expose him before. 'She got me good'. Like she made good on those threats. When he stared at her with those deranged eyes and making threats of his own through the thin car glass, she didn't bat an eye. Looking back,

she wasn't frightened at all. Why? Because she was really just a tough old bird who lived in a rough part of the city? Or because she knew what was going on all along? Because she knew him? Because she was in on it somehow? That wouldn't be unheard of-

"Ether."

She had almost forgotten she was on the phone. "Huh?"

"I think you should just go back home. We don't need you for this. Thornbrush already headed out."

"Uh-huh." She wasn't going home. She was going to visit a Mrs. Sherry Weaver. Whether the informant was lying or not, she had to try SOMETHING.

"We'll call you tomorrow if we need you."

"Sounds good."

They hung up. Adora says goodbye to Entrapta, thanking her. She walks back to her car, noticing how fast the sky seems to be darkening. She can't help but feel like the quickening night is an omen. She would go back home right after this. She just wanted to talk to Diego's old neighbor real quick, feel her out a bit. On the way, she dialed Angella.

"Chief."

"Detective Ether, I trust you've had a restful day."

Oh, they could skip the pleasantries. "We've got a mole."

"Pardon?"

"Somebody on our end is feeding information to the cartel kingpin."

"What makes you say that?"

"It's a long story and I'll come in tomorrow and explain but right now I'm-"

"Are you driving?"

"I'm on my way to see Diego's old neighbor. She-"

"Detective, I removed you from this case. You will do no such thing-"

"I'll fill you in tomorrow."

"I am giving you a direct order to-" Click.

Sorry, Chief. I'll take hell for that later, but we have to know. The sun has finally set and the last of the kids on this side of town have gone back inside for the night. She remembered riding her bike out here with Catra occasionally. She watches as the buildings get more and more shoddy and run down- big cracks in the sidewalk and plants sticking through in some places. The disparity between here and the west was depressing -it wasn't right. Someday she would see it all change.

She slows down as she approaches the street, hoping she remembers which house it is. She sees it -barred windows nestled in an old, dark brown paint which had been chipped at and worn away by weather and time and neglect. The roof was missing a few shingles and had moss growing on it. The lawn was mowed, but full of weeds. No flowers, no shrubs, really not much other life at all. Adora pulled up to the curb right in front -she wouldn't need to be there very long. She'd be lucky if this woman even talked to her now that she wasn't technically a witness for any open cases. Against her better judgement, she left the car unlocked.

She walks up the steps, hearing some sounds around back - voices. Did she have company over? There were no cars out front? Somebody must have pulled around the back side of the house. Adora approaches somewhat slowly, unable to make out any of the voices. Although she's sure none of them are Mrs.

Weaver's. She steps up to the entryway and rings the doorbell, holding the button down for just long enough to be obnoxious yet still polite.

A tall woman in a dark suit opens the door. Huntara. She just left the club. Why would she be...here? Was the DEA even involved in her questioning to begin with? Did she just get the name from the file? Or...was she the person on the inside? Oh shit. The air felt thicker than usual -more humid maybe - and Adora knew she had to walk on eggshells. Either she was paranoid and about to make a fool of herself, or she was about to make a stand for her life. She gave a smile. "Thornbrush, what a surprise." Huntara didn't return it "I'm here to ask Mrs. Waver a few questions."

"Well, that IS a surprise." Apparently not one Huntara was excited about. "...and a coincidence. That's exactly why I'm here." Adora cocked her head. "I've been thinking about my conversation with the informant since this morning and something they said caught my attention."

"Ah. I see. Me too."

Huntara shifted her weight from one foot to the other. "I take it you heard from King. Shame about those two at the club. I liked them." There was something about her eyes -something not there, something missing -that made the words just feel cold. "It's always the good ones that end up being loose ends." Adora's palms started to sweat. "But that's why we have you, Ether. You're a good cop. You get to the bottom of things if you keep working like this." It's always the good ones.

Adora wasn't sure what else do to but pretend everything was normal."Do you think I could come in and ask Mrs. Weaver a few questions?" The twitch of Huntara's mouth told her that the thin veneer of pleasantness in this conversation was all but over. The alarm bells had started to sound in her head. Be smart about this.

"It's okay, Ether. I've got a handle on this." And with that, Adora understood. Mrs. Weaver couldn't answer anyone's questions

anymore. She was probably dead on the floor in there -another loose end. “Why don’t you go back home, go be with that lost kitten of yours.” Kitten. “I get the feeling she’s not safe until all this is all over.” A warning. No, a threat. The coldness from her stare seeped into Adora’s bones, causing the hair to rise on the back of her neck and her arms.

Adora nods, placing a hand on her chin. Play it off. You may walk away from this yet. Prepared to reach for her gun at the slightest movement, she manages to force a scoff. “Yeah, King said I should go home too. Maybe you’re right.” She dropped her hand and put it on her hip under the jacket -a casual display of her holster. It was almost instinct but it may have been a mistake. “If you’ve got it under control here, I’ll leave you to it.”

Huntara knew she knew. There’s no way she didn’t. Her only hope was to get to the car. There was at least thirty feet of open yard between here and there -she wouldn’t stand a chance in a standoff right now. Adora forces herself to turn her back to Huntara anyways, heart thrumming in her fingertips, praying for something, some distraction -anything that gives her an opportunity to-

“All loaded up back there-.” A deep male voice from inside the house, she knows Huntara turns, just for a second. That was it. Your only chance. Run.

Each step might as well have been slow motion. It feels like she’s dragging ham hocks through water but she knows from years of running that her feet are flying. It’s only taken six strides to cover half the distance -really, they’re more like bounds. Only a few more and she can get in the passenger-

A fiery pain tears through her body -back to front -causing her step to falter. She sees the blood and hears the pop and she knows she’s been shot. Even though her body is thrown off and stops moving in that efficient, mechanical way, she was already traveling so fast. She makes it somehow on sheer momentum,

slamming into the side of the car and sliding into the seat -she's on autopilot. Go.

The window shatters as she moves into the driver seat and starts the car -another bullet, no doubt nearly missing her. The wheels start spinning and more shots ring out from behind her, shattering more windows in the back. She assesses herself. She's definitely bleeding -her body feels like it's leaking energy, warmth, and it hurts but not in the way she thought getting shot might. Then her mind is travelling faster than the car, which is speeding down the end of the residential street and drifting around the corner, ignoring the stop sign. The last thing she sees in her mirror before the street disappears from view is a black Cadillac peeling out from behind the house into the street. They're coming.

Huntara was the insider. No wonder the DEA supposedly 'couldn't pin down' a location for their operations -because they were getting paid off, or bribed with...other things. She can hear Catra say that Huntara spends half her time in private rooms. Doing what? Adora shivered, disgusted. And she was cleaning up 'loose ends'. Why did she want me to go to the club? Was King in on it? Was it an ambush? No. They wanted me out of the way so they could get to Catra. She ground her teeth. I should have known better than to leave her alone. She would call Catra as soon as she could. But right now…

She nearly got wrecked by a UPS truck running a red light. Huntara was closing in from behind. Of course, now that she wasn't in a squad car she didn't have a fucking radio. She hadn't had time to get one installed in her car yet. She couldn't call King -couldn't risk him being part of this."Goddammit…" She fumbled for her phone, almost hitting a cyclist. Her speedometer read 58 now, weaving traffic and hoping to God she wasn't going to crash before she could reach the freeway. She had to get there before she accidentally killed somebody -or before somebody purposefully killed her. She dialed 911. It rang once, twice.

"911, what's your emergency?" Of course, this poor dispatch person wouldn't know a damn thing.

“I’m a police officer, off duty. I’ve been shot. I’m driving towards the freeway with the perpetrators following close behind.”

“O-okay. Where have you been shot?” Goddammit.

“The abdomen.” I don’t have time for this. “Listen. Please. I need you to have all patrol cars in the southwest area to head for the freeway -I need backup. Do you understand? I’m in a white Dodge Charger and the shooters are in a blacked out Cadillac Escalade.” She took a corner too sharp and skidded into the other lane, earning honks -her front bumper barely scraping against somebody else’s.

“Ma’am, I need you to stay on the phone. Tell me where exactly you are. I’ll get help on the way.”

“I’m heading for the freeway.” Another red light. “Near exit 47.” Where are all the fucking patrol cars when you need them?

“And you’re a police officer?”

Oh for the love of- “YES! I’m a detective with the B.M.P.D. I’m off duty, being chased by the people who shot me. They are still armed. Blacked out Cadillac Escalade. No license plates.” She checks her rearview mirror to find them still three cars back. Another shot was fired out the window with frighteningly good aim given all the movement, but it missed, putting a hole in her windshield and causing it to crack. Fuck. The cracks started spreading and it was getting in the way of her vision. Fuck. She takes a blind corner onto the on-ramp, essentially making a u-turn and cutting off several other cars that swerve to miss her. This one straight-shot strip of road is going to be her only chance.

Gas pedal halfway to the floor and flying close to blind, with everything she’s got Adora throws a punch at the broken glass. Both her hand and her abdomen complained -oh yeah, she’d almost forgotten about the bullet wound. The glass doesn’t come out but she can tell it’s close. The Escalade is gaining. She gives one more good throw and -when she hears glass shatter, she

could cry she's so happy, even as some pieces fly back towards her. She floors it. Thank God for this douchey car -it may actually save my life.

"I'm on the freeway!" She has to scream into the phone over the wind, the speedometer on the dash creeping quickly towards 90.

"There's at least three units already in the area now in route."

She's already having a hard time keeping her eyes open against the now open air flow, still going in and out of the three lanes to avoid normal-paced traffic. This is way too goddamn fast already. She really doesn't want to, but she has to get this thing going faster -they're still closing in. 100. 105. 110. If she crashes like this, she will die -no question. But if they catch her, she's dead anyways…

Finally, when Adora passes 115, she sees flashing lights in the distance -two coming up from behind, cars moving out of the way to let them through, and one ahead she's catching quickly. Huntara doesn't seem to have noticed yet, she's still trying to close the gap to get another shot. Ope, now she must have. The Cadillac hits the breaks and veers off the freeway with a screech at the exit they're passing, swerving around the slower vehicles. Adora watches in her rearview mirror as the two patrol cars follow, feeling relief only for a moment. Catra was a loose end. Huntara no doubt had access to her address. I have to call her. Wait, Angella has to know too.

She catches up to the third patrol car, which pulls up alongside her, then drops behind. They pull off to the shoulder together. Only when she turns the key does she realize how hard she's shaking. She could be going into shock. She's lost a lot of blood. The other officers step out of the car and she recognizes Andrew Seahawk's face in her window. "My God, Adora! What the hell kind of promotion did you take? They gave you all the action at once!" He gloves up and helps her apply pressure, which hurts like a bitch. The ambulance pulls up alongside the car. She's starting to feel a little dizzy. Or maybe nauseous? Or both. Both.

“Seahawk, you have to call Chief Angella, now. Tell her the DEA is in on it. Huntara is dirty.”

He looks confused -and worried. She must look worse than she feels. “Adora, I do-”

There’s no time. No time. “Do it! She’ll know what it means. Please. It’s important.”

In the ambulance, they’re attaching wires to her and putting bandages on and trying to talk to her but she can’t seem to focus on what they’re saying. She knows they’re trying to be reassuring but she just wants them to shut up and listen. Her vision is fading a little around the edges and her hearing kind of comes and goes with the fuzziness. She feels so sluggish....They have to get Catra somewhere safe -they’re coming for her - but the paramedics just don’t understand. She needs to be somewhere public...She steals a pen from one of them taking notes and starts writing as good as she can: Catra (Sister) 960-755-2384. One of them asks if this is her contact and she nods. “Call her. Get her out.”

“We’ll be at the hospital soon, and then…” And then nothing. Her consciousness slips away.

Mother Knows Best

Chapter Summary

Catra sees Adora in the hospital, but she's not the only visitor.

Chapter Notes

Sorry this took so long, fam. Life is crazy these days! ALSO I created a spotify profile just for this story. (Username is Catradora 4Life, but I think you can also look it up by the other weird long name: 7raapf1zz4pp5bmps7xr3vxj6) Check out the playlist "Privacy" -that's the one Catra likes to have on when shit gets, you know, hot af. I will be adding more eventually but I like the playlists that are there already :)

Catra is out of the car before the engine stops, even though she has no idea where she's going. She's barely able to keep herself from running and these two are walking so, so painfully slow. When an information counter comes into view, she does sort of bound to it. "There was a police officer brought in here tonight, Adora Ether. She's supposed to be in surgery. You called me."

The woman behind the counter gave a startled albeit empathetic look. "If she's in surgery, she was probably taken to the ICU. If you head outside and go to the next building over, you can wait for her there. Check in at the big main desk."

So they turn around and go back outside. Catra breaks away from Bow and Glimmer and wonders who made hospitals so fucking big anyways. They could at least make the names of things more obvious. Who names a building Splithoff Pavilion anyways? Why not just call it what it is? Emergency Surgery Building. Again, once they're through the doors, she practically runs to the desk. She tries again, words tumbling out faster and a bit less carefully this time. "There was a police officer brought here with a gunshot wound. I'm her emergency contact. Can we see her?"

“Name please?”

“Catra, C-A-T-R-A, Mendoza, with a z.”

The woman typed away. “Ahhh, I’m not seeing anyone by that name.”

Catra started tapping her nails against the fancy marble countertop -the constant click her only comfort. “Oh, you meant her name? Her name is Adora Ether, E-T-H-E-R.”

This woman’s computer was too slow. “And her date of birth?” Glimmer, Bow, and Catra all say it at the same time. The two of them look at Catra with an expression that irritates her to no end -like they were surprised. Of course I know her fucking birthday.

“It looks like she’s still in surgery. Feel free to wait here. I’ll have somebody come and talk to you once she’s out.” More waiting? Couldn’t she go watch or something? The brunette groans. She wanted to pull her hair out. She couldn’t take this waiting bullshit.

Glimmer tried to pull gently at her arm toward the seating area -she yanked it away but followed suit. She sat, staring intently as the woman behind the counter called somebody on the phone. Then typed something on her computer, then talked to the other lady next to her. She would be ready whenever they were called. Bow leaned forward in his seat. “You know...she’ll call us when they’re ready. There’s nothing else we can do right now. Try not to be so worried. I’m sure Adora’s going to be fine.”

Catra’s throat constricted at the word ‘fine’ and her heart followed soon after. She’d better be goddamn fine. Catra crossed her arms over her chest, looking away. “Psh. I’m not worried.” Bow raised his eyebrows and motioned with his eyes to her leg, which was bouncing up and down. She forced it to still, ready to claw somebody’s eyes out. Everything was so...ugly, an ugly brick red-orange. “So what? I have like, ADHD or some shit. Get off my back.” She was feeling more and more out of control. She was

either going to scream or cry or both if somebody didn't take her to Adora right now.

This time Glimmer tried comforting her -prodding her emotions, poking her with that fucking stick of nicities. "I'm sure any minute now they'll come out and tell us they were able to remove the bullet." Cry. She was going to cry.

Adora. Was. Shot. She was bleeding. She was alone. Even though her head was turned away, Catra was sure they could see the single tear that escaped while her will power faltered. Her leg started to bounce furiously again -it was the only thing keeping her together, the only release of energy she would allow. Hell, she was already so obvious. They knew she was scared -she may as well own up to it a LITTLE bit. She had to save some face. She forced herself to breathe evenly, clearing her throat.

"I'm a little worried..." Another tear fell and she bit her lip to stop the rest of the words from falling out: 'that I'll never hold her again.' She stared at the one light-colored center tile on the floor to ground herself. Somebody's hand blocked her sight of it, relaxed and fingers open -an invitation to hold it. Catra lifted her head to look at Glimmer next to her, trying to come up with some remark to maintain her personal bubble, but the expression on her face made Catra forget about that. She was crying too. She was afraid, even though just a few moments ago she'd sounded so sure.... The look in her eyes told Catra they were the same. Well, not really. Glimmer made herself vulnerable and she was open, caring and supportive, but Catra could tell they were the same in that those were lessons she learned from Adora. The way she had touched their lives was so profound -neither of them would know what to do without her.

Without saying a word, Catra links her pinky with Glimmer's. She's not sure why she does it or why it makes her feel better, but it does. She's still afraid, but she's not alone. Glimmer smiles at her in a way that makes her heart ache and she has to look away again. Then they wait. They wait and wait and fucking wait, until finally, somebody comes out and calls "Those here for Adora

Ether.” Catra literally jumps out of her chair so fast that several people around them stare. It’s a big man in scrubs. Catra thinks it’s odd that a doctor should have a beer gut -aren’t they supposed to be healthy?

“Yes, we’re here.”

“Follow me.” He leads them through some double doors, down a hall, through more doors, another hall -Jesus. How big is this place? Catra knows she won’t be able to get out of here without a guide. They stop in a hallway and Catra’s eyes are glued to the window next to them. Is Adora in there? Or is it the next one down? Is she awake? Can she see us? Her hands are itching to yank open the handle and walk in. Who’s that? There’s a police officer standing on the other side of the door clad in the full vest and get-up gear. Why? He nodded at the doctor.

“She had a couple lacerations, likely from the broken glass…” Why was there broken glass? “She took a bullet in the abdomen, which split into a few pieces and scattered.” Glimmer gasped. Oh god… “All things considered, the removal went quickly and without complications -thankfully -but it was still an invasive procedure. She’ll need to stay with us for about a week so we can monitor her, make sure there’s no infection, things like that.” So Catra would be staying at the hospital then. She could do that. “Oftentimes when bullets shatter like that it gets everywhere but hers was pretty clean. She was lucky, really.” He gestured to the wall next to them and Catra once again fought the urge to throw the door open. “She’s in here. The anaesthesia should wear off in the next hour or so.” He smiled, shaking his head. “The paramedics say she was trying to get them to make phone calls for part of the drive over here -she would hardly sit still. That’s a new one on me.”

Catra gave a dry laugh. “Sounds about right.” The girl was nonstop.

“So can we go in with her?” Bow put his arm around Glimmer.

“Of course.”

For some reason, Catra hesitated before grabbing the door, nodding towards the officer. “Why is he here?”

Glimmer and Bow seemed to just now realize there was another person standing there. “Seahawk! What are you doing here?” They knew each other?

“I’m basically here as Adora’s bodyguard.”

“How did you find out she…”

Catra pulled open the door and left them there to talk. Why would Adora need a bodyguard? Because somebody was still after her? Did she have a run in with Hordak’s goons? When the door closes behind her, she pushes all those thoughts away. They would be fine. They were in a hospital. Adora was recovering. It was all going to be okay. Adora is-

She doesn’t know what she had been expecting, but this wasn’t it. It’s like the camera zooms out and Catra takes it all in at once. Adora is unconscious in the bed -the smell of sterilization all over this plain, too-clean room. She’s got a couple bandages over her eyebrow and forehead, a larger wrap around her hand and wrist, an IV in her other hand taped to her skin and hooked up to a drip, some tubes up her nose, and wires attached to her chest. It’s a harrowing sight that chills her to the core. This person looked vulnerable -fragile, even. Adora was strong and brave and goddammit, she was supposed to be indestructible! She remembers Adora twirling her around like she weighed nothing, holding her, fighting those two men. She might as well be on her deathbed in here with all this stuff on her. There’s a soft little beeping noise she knows is Adora’s heart beat -she can see it on the little monitor. The brunette can’t help but wonder how such a deep and steady sound -no, feeling- could be reduced to such a high, small noise. But she needed it. She needed to hear that constant beep more than she needed to breathe herself right now.

She just wanted her to wake up. To see those beautiful blue eyes. To hear her laugh.

"Adora…" The single strained word opens the floodgates again and now that they're alone, the tears flow freely. Catra pulls one of the chairs in the room and sits by the bed, resting her head on the side next to Adora's arm. "You never should've gotten mixed up in any of this -with me." It's my fault.

She lets herself cry until she hears the door open and two pairs of footsteps on the cold tile floor. "...jeez."

"Could be worse." Catra clenches her fist. How? How could this be worse? Well, she could be dead. The thought causes a sob to rise in her throat but she chokes it down. She can't do that in front of people. Besides, she's feeling instinctively possessive. She knows that these are Adora's friends and that they care about her too, but Catra can't help but wish that she could just be alone with her.

"Well...I'm kind of hungry. I might go get some food somewhere and come back. Hopefully by then she'll be awake. Glim, do you want anything?"

"No, but I think I'll come with you -give her time before she wakes up." Catra couldn't help but feel like she was talking about her and not Adora when she said 'her. She's somewhere between angry and thankful -or rather, she feels both.

"Okay. Catra, do you want us to bring you anything? Coffee? Tea? Food?" Why are they so nice? She shakes her head. She wants to give a verbal answer but her throat is still tight and she just wants them to go. The door opens and she starts to relax, but they hesitate.

"Are you sure you don't want anything? Did you even eat dinner?"

"I'm fine, thanks."

And they finally leave her in peace next to Adora's sleeping body. She looks like she's cold. Catra reaches up and gently touches the

blonde's fingertips. She is cold. I mean, of course she's cold. She got shot for Christ's sake. Catra pulls up the blanket at her feet, placing it just above her hips, scared to pull it higher where it might touch the wounds. She had no idea about how this stuff worked -that was always Adora's thing. The more Catra watched her, the easier it was to convince herself that she looked the same as ever, just sleeping. Her hair was messy but in that same stupid ponytail she always wore. Yes, they were both just the same. All that heartbreak she caused both of them to leave her, to save her from herself, and the misery of ignoring Adora's stil-incessant attempts to get through to Catra, for literal years. And here they were again anyways. Life had a funny way of dealing out cruel irony.

It couldn't have been very long, but Catra hears the door open and she's immediately annoyed again, ready to tell those obnoxious friends of Adora's to buzz off and leave her be -YES, she was SURE she didn't want anything. "Catra, dear." Her heart stops and she's frozen in place, eyes wide but unseeing. That voice. How did she even know they were here? "I'm so glad you're here."

No. She couldn't do this -not today. Not right now. She couldn't face her, couldn't face the only nurturing parental figure she had growing up, who she then left without so much as a thank you. She couldn't face her now that her oldest daughter was here in hospital because of Catra. She couldn't have that conversation standing here over her unconscious body, wrapped in bandages and wires and gauze. 'Hey, nice to see you again. I got your daughter tied up in more of my bullshit and now she's half-dead.' Absolutely not. She was going to barf.

She heard soft footsteps along with a clack of something else. Catra's body turned on its own to discover what made the noise -a cane. Razz had aged a bit since they last saw each other. The crow's feet in the corners of her eyes were deepened and she had kind wrinkles elsewhere. Her hands looked a bit more frail and the slightly cane-abled limp-step on the right side made her look older than she really was. But her eyes were still dark and all-knowing

and full of unconditional love. Their powers of compulsion made Catra remember how horrible she was, remember their last encounter. Even as Catra -ungrateful and angsty -ran away from the care and warmth of that family, all this woman could say was 'be safe'. And now here they were because, what did she do? The exact opposite of what she was told, as usual. And Adora was the one to suffer the consequences, AS USUAL.

Hands came to rest on her shoulders in a way that Catra's body remembered and she broke. Feeling small and powerless and six years old again, she let herself be pulled into a hug and she cried openly. "Razz, I, I-didn't...Adora, she...I'm s-so sorry."

A hand gently pressed against the back of her head. "Shh, shh, shh. You have nothing to be sorry for. Adora chose this job because she wanted to help people. She is willing to put herself in harm's way to do what she feels needs to be done. You know that."

Catra's hands pulled at the older woman's shawl -it smelled like her, like their house. "No, no. It's not the job -it's m-me! She got mixed up in this because of me, because-"

"Because she thought it was the right thing to do, love." Razz let her go and Catra was ashamed of how wet her face was, but she couldn't wipe it because the older woman was holding her hands. Now there was nowhere to hide. "She came out that way -stubborn, determined -from the time she could roll over." The way her eyes lit up when she looked at Adora broke Catra's heart, but it was hard not to feel the warmth from her love standing this close. "I'll never forget the time we found a box of kittens on the side of the road -no more than two weeks old." Catra sniffed. "She was about five and half -this was right before we got to have you for the first time, actually."

Got to. As if she had been some kind of peasantry, a gift. Catra had been a little shit and she knew it. The story continued. "I tried to tell Adora that they probably wouldn't make it without their mother because they need warmth. So what does she do?

She curls up with them in her bed all day, as much as she can. She doesn't play with her friends, she doesn't go outside -she's just there. When she has to go to preschool, she keeps them in a box next to a little heater. For almost two and a half weeks she did that! I know it killed her to not be up and bouncing off the walls -you know how active she was. But she did it."

They both turned to look at her again. Razz sighed. "Yes...she's always been that way." She paused, letting Catra's hands go and clasping them over the top of her cane. It was a beautiful woven wooden cane -it was very on brand for Razz. "You can't change her, and she's going to make her own decisions -just like you -so you might as well just buckle up and go along for the ride wherever life takes you."

Catra can tell she's doing the thing -trying to tell her something without actually telling her. "Razz...I'm so sorry for...for leaving, the way I did, I...I just…"

She smiled. "I understand. There is nothing to forgive."

No, there really was. She didn't...she didn't understand. How could she possibly own up to all of this now? She had to though -Razz deserved to know the truth. Still, somehow "I...I can't lose her." was all that came out.

Razz nodded, a few stray grey hairs sticking out at odd angles. "Well then you'd better hurry up and tell her how you really feel." Catra's eyes widened with surprise. "It's about damn time." Wha...what? She had that look -the way her eyes glint.

"You...knew?"

She waved her hand at Catra. "Of COURSE I knew, dearie! Why else do you think I never formally adopted you?" Catra stood there, shaken. Because I was a bad kid? Because I didn't fit in with your family? "It couldn't have been more obvious if you ask me. But what do I know? I'm just a crazy old lady."

"I...can't…"

“Why not?”

Catra fumbled in her head to find the right explanation. “I’m sorry, it’s just-”

“Ah, ah! I’M not the one you need to apologize to.” The old woman’s eyes flickered over to Adora and Catra’s stomach twisted. “Call me when she wakes up.” And that was it -Razz was gone, in her usual fashion.

Catra just sits and watches her again, waiting for some sign of movement, of life. She pets Adora’s fingers gently with her own, draws shapes on her arm with her nails -gently, the way that calms her when she’s stressed. “I need you, Adora.” She lifts the other hand to hold the blonde’s cheek, brushing her thumb over her lips. I need you.” They part and it startles her. She sits up straight and watches in amazement as Adora’s head turns to the side and her eyebrows furrow. Catra tries not to scream and jump on her, but she does climb into the bed, not caring if it’s allowed or not. Careful to not lay on Adora, she stays uncomfortably on her side, smooshed against the railing. “Adora?” Her eyelashes flutter and Catra’s heart follows suit. “Adora, are you awake?”

Her head lulls sleepily to the side. She still looks confused. “Hey, hi.”

“Hi.”

“You’re here!” Adora was being kind of...drunk?

Catra wanted to kiss her so bad. “Where else would I be?”

“Where are we?”

Uh oh. “The hospital?”

Adora groaned. Was she still high from the anesthetic? “Shiiiiiiiiiiiit.” Her head snapped up. “No, wait! You can’t be here! You have to- oh…” She relaxed again. “Nevermine, you’re in the hospital with me. I get it now.” She turned her head back to Catra

beside her, blue eyes sparkling even in this dim room. She smiled that goofy grin. “Hi.”

Catra laughed and the tears clouded her vision for a moment before spilling down her cheeks again. Adora was okay. She was okay and she was HERE and...she heard Razz: ‘it’s about damn time.’ She was right. Adora’s eyebrows furrowed. “Why are you crying? This is great. They called you like I asked, and now you’re here, and I’m here, and look, there’s a TV.”

God, she was so cute. And a dork -HER stupid, amazing dork. “Because you’re an idiot.” Catra tried to wipe her face. Her pride wouldn’t let her say the words like a blubbering child.

Again, Adora furrowed her eyebrows. “Well...so? You like me anyways, right?”

“I love you, Adora.”

Reunion

Chapter Summary

Adora wakes up in the hospital and her people are there :)

Chapter Notes

At this point, I will be as shocked as you at whatever comes out of my fingers. *shrug* It's gonna go where it's gonna go.

Adora is starting to feel half alive again -especially after stealing a couple french fries from Glimmer. Bow went out and got her a little thing of chocolate milk at a convenience store nearby, and her mom brought her an extra blanket -which to the hospital workers probably seemed a bit overbearing but she was actually thankful for it. Apparently these weird little scratchy robes hospitals make you wear are super thin and breezy. All things considered though, she feels pretty good. Well, as good as you're going to feel when you get betrayed by a partner and shot in the back and in a car chase and have emergency surgery. It had been an incredibly long day. Spending the morning with Catra feels like it was a week ago already, and there's definitely some blank spaces in between the freeway and the conversations happening now in her little hospital room that she can't seem to fill. She doesn't really remember the last couple hours and she somewhat desperately wishes she could.

She could tell by the way Catra reacted when she told Glimmer that she didn't remember anything before Bow gave her the chocolate milk that something was wrong. When the brunette sort of stiffened up, Adora knew they had probably had some kind of semi-important conversation while she was loopy. Adora hoped she didn't say something that offended her -or worse, left her feeling rejected. That was the last thing she wanted to do. This felt like waking up from being totally blackout drunk, or...well...surgery. She'd only ever had one before and it wasn't anything major. When she got her wisdom teeth removed at

fourteen, apparently while she was still waking up, she started hitting on all of the nurses and Catra had definitely been a little bit jealous. She teased Adora for at least a week, but there was a little bit of venom laced in with her playful words -the cue to know she was upset. Right now, as hard as she tried, Adora didn't remember a damn thing prior to about forty minutes ago, but Catra wasn't teasing her like that...so...it must have been something different.

It was kind of...nice though, being here with everyone. It was absolutely bat-shit bizarre, but nice. If Adora had been asked a week ago if she thought there would ever be a time that Catra, her mother, and her best friends would all be together in her hospital room, she would've said no way. Hell, if she'd been asked if she thought her and Catra would ever be in the same room together she would have said no. But here they all were. Catra was being somewhat quiet, but she seemed okay -a complete surprise considering how long it had been since she and Razz had spoken. Then again, Adora's mother always did sort of have this special way of communicating with Catra. Especially when she was younger, there were times when she could get through to her in ways Adora just couldn't.

The conversations were kept light-hearted in this company, which was probably for the best, but she didn't forget about what King had said: the two people killed at the bar and the envelope. Could Catra really be more involved than she'd let on? She wouldn't lie about that, right? If nothing else, Adora had to warn Catra that they were going to ask her more questions. Plus, Catra was still considered a 'loose end', they might come looking for her. Adora was glad Seahawk was posted up by the door. Even if he was a goof sometimes, he was there when it counted and she felt safer.

"Adora," Glimmer reached out her hand. "Your phone is ringing. Do you want to answer it?"

The blonde shook her head, content, feeling like for once, she could just be for a night. "I think it's from your boss? Her name is

Angela right?" My boss? If the number isn't from the station then she's calling on her personal phone.

Adora holds out her hand for the phone. "Angella." It was from her personal line. God, what now? She swipes. "Ether."

"My god, you're awake? I was just planning on leaving you a voicemail. How are you feeling?"

Adora looked around the room at the people she cherished most - safe, for now. "I feel great, chief." Her smile was genuine. "Haven't you heard? Starting today, I'm on vacation! Well, 48-50 benefits for temporary disability, but, same thing."

"Somehow, Ether, I doubt you'll be gone long, even if I ASKED you to stay away -WHICH, mind you, I DID." Well...she got me there. "At any rate, I'm glad you're alright. I called because I wanted to warn you to be extra vigilant. Huntara was caught shortly after you were taken to the hospital, but it appears somebody broke into your home shortly after and I'm certain it's related. Your neighbors called 911. One of the officers who got the call recognized the address as yours and called me -word spread fast about your situation."

Adora took a deep breath, still feeling oddly calm. That had been what she was afraid of -maybe that's why she was fine, because she'd been expecting it. "I see." Everyone else was watching her and waiting with wary eyes, almost like they were afraid she was going to try and get up and walk right out the hospital doors and back to work.

"As of right now, it doesn't look like anything was stolen, but we'll need you to confirm that. They were definitely looking for something."

Adora's eyes fall on Catra, standing up against the wall, arms crossed. "No, not something. SomeONE." As defiant and stone-cold as she could make herself appear, the woman was vulnerable. Adora's heart pumped with just a bit less 'oomf' than

usual at the thought of Catra being back at the house at the time of the 'break-in'. The little monitor beeping above her bed sped up just a little bit -Bow and Glimmer turned to look at it and then back to her.

"Yes, I'm sure they were. I'd like to keep you and her both under protection for the next two weeks or so -at least -only people we really trust."

"I'm surprised you sent Seahawk. There's plenty of flammable chemicals in a hospital." Everyone knows the man has nearly set himself and surrounding buildings on fire at least five times.

The light-hearted half-joke goes unacknowledged. The other woman's voice stays low. "These trials are going to be ugly, Ether. We have no idea how widespread or how deep the corruption runs, and until we rip it out by the roots, you might have a target on your back."

Oh, it was going to be a nightmare. "I know."

"Rest up for now. I'll need your mind at 110% to put this puzzle together."

"Will do."

"We'll be in touch. I'm glad you're okay."

"Me too. Bye Angella." She hangs up the phone and everyone is looking at her expectantly. She really doesn't want to alarm any of them, but they also have a right to know what's going on - especially Glimmer and Bow, who's space had been violated. Had they been home...Adora clears her throat. "Some people broke into the house." Glimmer gasps.

"What?"

"Why?"

“My guess is that they were looking for Catra. Either to…” She hesitates. “...to take her or to make sure she can’t spill their secrets.” She tries to censor it at least a LITTLE, but everyone understands what she means. She can’t read Catra’s expression. She must be scared.

“Oh my God…”

“I’m sure you and Bow will have to answer some questions when you get home, but they’ll probably come and talk to Catra at some point. I think you should try to either stay in a hotel for at least a few days, or maybe Bow’s dads’ house -at least until I’m back on my feet.” She sighed heavily. “I’m sorry I got you guys tangled up in all this.”

Catra scowled at her. “You? I don’t think so. I’m the one they’re-”

Bow gives her a smile and shakes his head. “This is nobody’s fault. It’s a tough situation, and yeah, it’s kinda scary, but we’ll do what needs to get done to stay safe, and we WILL be okay. All of us. My parents would be happy to have us, and maybe Catra too?” He looked back at her.

She shakes her head and crosses her arms -Adora almost wants to laugh. She makes herself look like such a child sometimes - anxiety and closed off. “I’m staying with Adora.”

“In the hospital? Where are you going to sleep?” She raises her eyebrows and shrugs, giving no verbal response.

“Is that even allowed?”

“I don’t care.”

“Catra…” Adora gives a gentle warning glance, but she knows it’s technically allowed, and she wouldn’t mind the company if she really is going to be stuck here for days. Catra is far more entertaining than whatever god-awful soap opera channels are on the TV.

“I’m not leaving you until you walk out of this hospital.” This was very clearly going to be one of those times where, whatever Catra wanted, Catra got, because she would not take no for an answer.

Adora shrugs. “Okay.” She turns to her mother, “Mom, you should think about staying somewhere else too. Is there any chance you could sleep in your office? There are people there pretty much around the clock aren’t there?”

She waved her hand. “Ah, don’t worry about me. If somebody comes into the house, I’ll give ‘em the ol’ Razzle-Dazzle.” Both her and Catra smiled at the thought. Still, Adora was worried. “It’s getting pretty late for me though. I’ll let you kids have your fun. Call me if there’s anything I can do, dearie. Otherwise, I’ll come back in a couple days to check on you.” She came over and hugged Adora. She winced when she tried to sit up a little bit - apparently the rib the bullet ‘bounced’ off of was still unhappy.

Razz walked over to Catra and took her by the shoulders. “And I trust I’ll be seeing you soon.” She kissed her forehead and was gone. Bow and Glimmer stay a bit longer before heading out. They’re going to go stay with Bow’s dads afterall, which is good. Then it’s just Adora and Catra and the occasional nurse coming to check on her. As badly as she wants -needs -to know what was said right after she woke up, to know why Catra was being so...almost shy? She has to tell Catra about the man and woman from the club…

Catra is sitting next to the bed, arms relaxed on the edge, sort of twiddling her fingers. She looks unsure, an expression that always appears very misplaced on the brunettes striking and otherwise attention-commanding features. She looks so beautiful like this - mismatched clothes and messy hair, hardly any makeup. Adora just wants to talk to her about good things, happy things...maybe even about them...but she has to tell her. She has to. Catra deserves to know, and it’s better she hears from her than from somebody else.

“Catra…” How to start… “...there’s something I have to tell you…”

“I already know this outfit is hideous. I threw on the first thing I could get my hands on, so-”

“No, no…” She watches Catra’s playful smirk fall. “It’s about something that happened today -at the club.” Catra’s eyebrows tick together and she sits up a bit taller. Adora doesn’t miss her swallow. Maybe she really does know more than she’s letting on…

“I got a call today...Catra...the club owner and one of the women who work there are dead.” There’s a still moment of silence after the words fill the room.

Adora could see the color of her face change and sort of wan. Her breaths became a bit more shallow and tears brim in her eyes, making them glow. “What woman.” Something about the way her voice strained and her bottom lip quivered suggested she already knew the answer. “What woman, Adora?”

“I don’t know her name. I just know she was a waitress and-”

“No.” Catra was shaking her head, tears streaming down her face.

This was awful. “She’s older, blonde-”

“No!” It was very clear she cared about this woman. Adora reaches her hand for Catra’s but she pulls away. “She’s fine. She said she was fine!” The way Catra’s voice cracks kills her.

Catra stands from her chair fast enough to make it wobble, and she steps away, pressing her palms to the side of her head, pacing. “She said she was…” Adora knows well enough that she’ll have to let Catra calm down on her own, but she’s never seen her this distraught. Catra paces, turning frequently and swearing in between the occasional heavy breath. It goes on like that for what felt like twenty minutes, just watching her process. She could see anger, fear, sadness -so much sadness -and pain. Catra was internalizing this, like she did everything, but how could Adora possibly stop her? She shouldn’t. If Catra really cared for these people, she would have to mourn in her own way. One thing was

for certain though: their murderer would suffer the consequences for their heinous crimes. Adora would make sure of that.

Catra stops by the door and turns to face her. Anger. She's feeling anger now. "How."

Adora feels trapped. Catra doesn't need to know the gruesome details...she could lie and say she doesn't know...but Adora knows she's going to find out eventually, either by digging herself or when she gets questioned again. Catra mistakes her silence for lack of understanding what her word means. "How did they die?"

Adora's fingers hold onto the sheet she's under -has the fabric been this soft the whole time? "He was shot."

Cata nods silently -fire in her eyes. "And Stace?" Her name was Stace?

"Catra..."

"How did she die, Adora?" She's hurting so badly. "I know you know." Don't make me do this. "Answer me."

"Catra-"

"Goddammit, Adora! Tell me!"

"She was strangled."

Catra's hand covers her mouth and she sinks to the floor against the wall, tucking her knees into her chest. Her face falls to her knees and she cries openly to herself, shattering Adora's heart. She would rather get shot again than watch her like this. All she wants to do is hold her -if Catra would let her. She cries her own tears for Catra's loss and for the needless loss of life to violence. Eventually the nurse comes back in to check on her one more time before the end of the night. He gives them both a funny look and Adora shakes her head when it looks like he might say something. He closes his mouth again and leaves.

She's lost in her thoughts until she hears stirring on the other side of the room where Catra has been curled up for who knows how long. The room has been dark except for blinking monitor lights and small slits shining through the shade slots from the hallway. Adora sees her shape -looking defeated -stand and move closer. She crawls up into the bed and Adora tries to make as much room for her as she can, her body complaining a few times when she twists wrong. Catra feels cold. The colors she sees, if any, are probably all cold too…

Adora pulls the blanket back and Catra throws a leg over Adora's, grabbing tightly onto the shoulder of her too-large robe. This moment feels reminiscent of when they were young and Catra had nightmares. Adora used to tell her stories to calm her down again, pet her hair and hold her hand. "She took me in." Catra's voice was rough -her rasp a bit more gritty than usual. "She was like a mother to me." This time it was Catra's turn to tell a story.

Adora just waited patiently and listened for whatever Catra was willing to tell her -needing to get out into the open. She starts slowly at first -bits and pieces in a quiet voice, nearly a whisper. "She looked out for me...kept me out of trouble." Adora can't help but wonder what kind of trouble Catra really got into these days. "Even if...even if somebody came through and, you know…" Adora waited. "...made an offer…" Ah. That. "...she found a way to talk Rob down from it. Not that he ever would have said yes either. Before, I mean." The thought made Adora's stomach twist uncomfortably. "We -Stace and I -sometimes we talked about starting over somewhere together to get away from all of the bullshit. Getting our own club, or maybe just a bar with a little dance studio attached to the back." Catra smiled and gave a bittersweet half-laugh, half-sob. "I wanted the studio and she wanted the bar. Sounds ass backwards right? You'd think I'd want the bar."

Adora put her hands over Catra's and she let her. "Not at all." She felt the goosebumps on the brunette's forearm. "Are you cold?" Catra just nods. "Why don't you get under the other blanket with me? It'll be warmer."

She seems to think about it for a moment. “Okay.” They work together to pull back the bigger blanket and Catra wiggles back into place between Adora and the side of the bed before relaxing again. Her tears have slowed, but Adora knows she’ll probably cry herself to sleep. Adora raises her non-wrapped hand to lightly brush fingers down the bridge of Catra’s nose. The motion feels awkward with her left hand, like she has to try extra hard to be so gently, but Catra doesn’t seem to notice. They fall asleep together, unsure of what tomorrow will bring -but at least they can handle it together.

Hopeful

Chapter Summary

Ask for fluff and you shall receive.

Chapter Notes

:)

Catra wakes up in the morning a bit startled. It takes her a moment to remember where she is. Adora's hand squeezes hers in assurance. She feels...dry. Her mouth and eyes might as well have sand in them, and her eyes feel like they're so swollen she must have two black eyes. Why t- oh. Stace is dead. She was murdered. Strangled. It could have been happening right while she was on the phone with her -or, rather, right after Stace hung up. Catra knew something was wrong but she never thought...that. Stace said she would be fine...Catra had cried until she couldn't anymore. Even now, this morning when the realization hits anew, her eyes won't produce tears. Instead she just feels...too much, not enough. She doesn't know what she feels. And when she thinks that she might have lost both Stace and Adora in the same day -to the same killers -she's...well...she's useless. Catra feels helpless, like there's nothing she can do. She could have just gone with Hordak willingly. She could've spared them all of this…

Adora holds her for a while without saying anything, which she's thankful for. Adora always gives her time -space to just be. Funny how after all this time, all the years apart, Adora still knows her better than anyone, knows what she needs and when she needs it. "Are you hungry?" Catra shakes her head, but her stomach gives a loud angry growl at the mention of food. Adora's lips curve in a warm smile. "When was the last time you ate?" The brunette just plays with the end of her now-loose ponytail, giving a noncommittal shrug. It's not a lie. She really doesn't know -it was definitely sometime yesterday. Probably when she ate with Adora.

“Well, I’M starving. My wallet should be somewhere near that chair. If you could go to the food court and bring me back two sandwiches, a salad, and some gatorade that would be wonderful.”

Catra’s heart ached and she couldn’t stop the small smile. “You’re such an idiot.” Adora didn’t like gatorade -she always said it was empty calories and sugar. Catra, on the other hand, loved it.

“What? I lost a lot of blood. I need to replenish my electrolytes.”

Any other time, Catra would have rolled her eyes, but even now -after everything she’d been through in the past two days, everything CATRA put her through -this big, dumb, beautiful, woman was trying to take care of HER. “Adora…” She really didn’t remember me saying the L-word, huh? Or maybe she just wanted an excuse to not have that conversation because she didn’t feel the same way anymore. But she still looks at me like that -like…

At some point while they were sleeping, one of the nurses had to have come in and opened the blinds. Morning light was streaming through, pushing the darkness back to the corners of the room. Adora’s eyes were bright as ever, their own light boring into her. The look she gives is still soft and inviting and...she wants me here -somehow. Catra’s eyes flicker to her lips and her hand follows, thumb tracing a soft lower lip lightly. The little beep that’s been such a steady white noise in the background speeds up a little. She looks at the monitor attached to the end of the bed -Adora’s pulse is 75. 79. 81. Catra smiles and turns back to find that lovable blush covering her cheeks.

Adora gives a single nod, acknowledging the transparency of her excitement. “Ah-h.” She plucks gently at one of the wires attached to her chest.“I’m glad they’re taking these leads off today.”

Catra smirks at her knowingly -proud. “What a shame. I could have fun with that.” She leans in and Adora kisses her back, slow and soft. Then Catra presses their foreheads together and she knows Adora still feels it too -this sense of belonging. This was

right. They were right. How could she have ever have been so stupid..."Adora, I…" A little voice tells her that she doesn't have the wherewithal to have this conversation with Adora fully, not right now. Later. But she can still own up to part of her feelings."I really...really missed you. I know that's not fair of me to say now. I know I-"

"Catra." Adora uses the back of her hand to lift Catra's chin to bring their lips together again, firmer this time. "I really, really missed you too." She's conflicted and full of so much guilt -for so, so many things. Both for things she's done and things she didn't do. Nevertheless, the words fill her with warmth. Somehow, her body is able to produce more tears, but Catra doesn't let them fall. They stay close like that for a few minutes, just holding onto each other. "Your lip looks like it's healing." Her lip? Oh, yeah. Catra had forgotten about her own injuries -the last 24 hours had been somewhat of an almost out-of-body experience.

She nods and gets up to get them both food -her leg complaining as soon as she starts moving. Riiiight, how could she forget about that huge freaking swollen bruise? She tries not to wince but Adora still catches it. "You didn't stretch like I told you to, did you?" Yeah, yeah. Catra gives Adora a glance over her shoulder and picks up her purse -like hell Adora was buying breakfast or lunch, or whatever this shitty hospital meal was.

"You can stretch me out again when you're up and walking." Beep-beep-beep. She blows Adora a kiss and steps into the cold hallway. A different officer is standing by the door now. He nods to her. She gives a half-wave. She's still not hungry, but she knows she needs to eat. Plus, Adora will be absolutely unbearable until she does, so she might as well just do it and get it over with. But how the actual fuck was she supposed to find the food court? Is there a food court? What exactly do hospitals have for food anyways? She wanders down hallway corridors for too long before finally asking somebody for directions -which she has to do once more on a different floor. When she finally does find food, it's about what she expected -overpriced and probably shitty salad and sandwiches, with a few breakfast items and snacks.

She gets herself a little egg-breakfast burrito, a cookie, some iced tea and a Caesar wrap for later. Then for Adora she gets the same breakfast burrito, a bran muffin, water, beef jerky, and some kind of 'meat-lover' sandwich. She can practically hear her saying something about the protein being good for making new enzymes or some shit. As long as Adora got better soon it didn't matter. Catra would do anything. The second they hand her the bag, she realizes that she has no idea what room Adora was in. Goddammit. She'd been in such a hurry yesterday, she didn't -UUUGh. She sighs out loud. Bags in hand, she walks around until she finds the reception desk again and tells the lady working there who's she's here for, yada yada. She has to wait -again -for somebody to come back and get her. This time, she pays attention to the turns and doorways leading up to the right hallway. I fucking hate hospitals.

When she finally gets back into the room, Adora smirks at her. "Get lost?"

Catra points a finger, holding up the bag. "I don't wanna hear it."

Adora wasn't kidding -she really was hungry. She devoured the breakfast burrito and half of her sandwich before Catra had even gotten halfway through her burrito. She gave the rest to Adora -she wasn't going to finish it anyways. They talked for a while, mostly about what was new with Adora's family. Razz had had a knee replacement that healed a bit irritably. Lonnie was in law school -she had apparently been somewhat inspired by Adora during her college years and found her own passion in law. Whereas Adora preferred family law -which, in hindsight, Catra had no doubts was a direct result of her own experiences growing up -Lonnie was really into immigration law. Kyle was an actor, of all things. Catra didn't believe her at first. "You should see him, Catra. He's grown up a lot. He's got a boyfriend, but, when I tell you women SWOON over him-"

"You're shitting me. KYLE. Women SWOON over KYLE."

“After high school, he was tired of being so lanky, so he got a personal trainer and started working out a lot and I’m telling you, just wait till you see him.” She hadn’t even thought about that, about seeing those two again now. Did they miss her? Would they be angry? Adora must have sensed her new sense of nervousness. “Hey. They’ll be really glad to see you.”

She was just about to deflect when there was a knock on the door. It’s the dark-haired guy that interrogated -er...asked Catra questions before -and another guy in a suit. Adora’s demeanor changed almost instantly and it rose the hairs on Catra’s neck. Her usual warm pools of blue turn icy and she looks ready to do something -to move. Beepbeepbeepbeepbeepbeep. Was this one of the partners that double-crossed her? How could they just walk in? “Put your guns on the table.”

The two men stopped, confused. “Ether-”

“Put. Your guns. On the table.” Catra moved her food out of her lap and next to the chair. This didn’t seem like a proper time to eat.

“Ether, we’re clean. We’re just here to talk.”

“With all due respect, I’m not taking any more chances.”

The man held up his hands. “Alright. I get it.” He left one hand up, and with the other, he slowly reached for his hip towards what must have been a holster. “Now, I’m not leaving my pistol just out in a hospital room, but I’ll take the clip out and empty the chamber. Yeah?” Catra doesn’t feel as tense anymore. If they were really here to murk them, they would have done it already and got out. Adora gave a small nod and he pulled out a handgun, sliding a thin clip out the bottom and holding it up for Adora to see. She relaxed as the other man next to him followed suit.
“I’m here to get your statement about what happened yesterday, but also the chief was worried you’d try running off somewhere. So, I’m glad to see you’re still in bed.” He glanced over at Catra -

she couldn't read his expression. "And while she's here, I might as well ask her a few more questions about what happened at the club." The club? About Stace. No way. Not right now.

"Sure."

The younger looking man next to 'King' pulled out a little recorder. "Can we record this?"

Adora nodded and looked at Catra. She shrugged. "Okay, great."

Catra just observed their back and forth."So yesterday, what the hell happened?"

"Something wasn't right about that SUV being clean, so I came to the precinct to check it out myself. I had forensics take a closer look at it and it came up too clean -sterile clean. She said somebody had like professionally cleaned it. While I was waiting I called our informant to see if I could get anything else out of them-"

"Thornbrush and I spoke with them right before then. We told you what we knew."

"No, you told me what Thornbrush wanted me to know. And like I said, at that point I suspected the ring had somebody on the inside -OUR inside- cleaning up bread crumbs that we NEEDED. Not to mention that Huntara was the last one to be around that car that I knew of. So, yeah, forgive me for not having complete faith in whatever it is you two told me about your meeting."

King shrugged. "Well, you caught on quicker than I did, so...you've got me there." He gestured with his hand for Adora to continue.

"The informant told me that if I wanted to fix this and save my…" She stopped and cleared her throat in the way she does when she's embarrassed. "If I wanted to help Catra, I'd have to go back to where all of this stopped AND started." What was she about to say just then? 'My' what?

“And you believed them?”

Adora shakes her head. “No. We-yes. I guess. I know this sounds crazy but we were already pulling at straws. I might as well have checked it out.”

“Checked what out, exactly? Sounds like they were just trying to confuse you. Stopped AND started?”

“It WAS confusing. The only thing I could think of was Diego’s place. I went back to try and talk to his neighbor again, the woman who called 911. I remembered how crazy hysterical he got once he realized it was her who called the police. When I got there, I didn’t see any cars. I knocked, and Huntara answered the door, but she wouldn’t open it all the way. That’s when I knew. She had absolutely no reason to be there.”

“No.”

“She wouldn’t let me talk to Miss Weaver, which tells me she was already dead, just like the two at the club.” Catra stiffens.

King nodded. “That makes sense. There was a body bag in the trunk of the car. We’re getting an ID now. I’m sure that’s who it is.” He gives a long blink. “God. What a fuckin’ mess.”

“She looked genuinely surprised to see me there, and now I understand why.” King furrowed his eyebrows in response, pulling his bottom lip between two fingers.

“Because she thought you were at home.”

“Right. She told you to tell me to come to the club. To what? You said there was nothing to do.”

“She was trying to get you out so she could take care of her.” He nodded towards Catra. She was mildly offended that they were talking about her like she wasn’t sitting right here. They were as casual as playing a good old fashioned game of Clue.

“Exactly. When she knew she couldn’t get there, she called somebody else to break into my house, but thankfully, everyone was already here to be with me.” Catra shivered. Things could have easily gone so, so wrong yesterday.

“Jesus, talk about good timing.” He could say that again. “But, so, back up here. So you ask to see Weaver, she says no. And she shoots you?”

“Pretty much.” Catra winces. That must have been terrifying. “There was this moment where we both knew that the other knew. She made this comment about ‘it’s always the good ones who end up loose ends’ and then she said I was a ‘GOOD’ cop.” Catra thinks about Rob and Stace. They were good. And they were apparently loose ends. Catra’s stomach squeezes uncomfortably at the thought of them lying dead together on the floor. Fuck.

“I wouldn’t have fared well in a stand-off. I know that about myself -I’ve never shot anyone before. I saw an opportunity to run and I took it, but she’d definitely been ready to pull the trigger. She shot me just before I reached the car. I took off and they pursued -the same car we’ve been seeing them drive.” The men are quiet, just thinking.

“I’m just glad you made it out okay. Thornbrush is going to go to prison for a long, long time.”

“Good.” She hadn’t meant to say anything out loud, but now everyone was looking at her. Had they really forgotten she was right there?

“Miss Mendoza,” She was definitely not used to people addressing her so formally. “For the record, I need to clarify your whereabouts during the day yesterday.” What?

“What?” Adora was looking at him sideways too?

“Was there anyone else home who could confirm your whereabouts?”

“King.Yes, my roommates were also home all day.”

“I’m just, making sure-”

She looked at Adora, furious. Adora also looked angry. “Does he think I killed them?” Without an answer she set her glare on him. “Do you think I killed my own- are you fucking serious?” Apparently her eyes were all juiced up again after that tea -with anger tears this time.

“No, no. I’m not accusing you of anything. It’s just a formality, in case -”

“In case I fucking killed them.”

He put his hand on his hip. “I’m really sorry for your loss. It’s clear that they meant something to you.”

Catra was having trouble controlling her temper. “Of course they did! I worked for them for almost seven years!”

“And this woman -Stace -” Catra hated that he used her name. He didn’t know her -he knew nothing about her. “You were special to her?”

Catra wrapped her arms around herself. Nobody had ever asked her that before -she’d never had to explain it. Yes, she was special to them. Or, at least, that’s what they had told her…”I don’t know. Yes? I think so. They were both good to me -her and Rob. But she was...like family.”

“And why would this guy, this Hordak guy, want to hurt her?”

Catra scoffed. “Because he’s a soulless narcissist who thinks he owns the world and nobody can touch him on top of his piles of money.” The officer waited for a more real answer. She sighed. “Stace knew about the other side of...business. She knew about Hordak, so he probably thought it would be best to...get rid of her. Plus, she was the one who told me to make a run for it. Maybe he was offing her for that. I don’t know.” Catra didn’t know

what was worse: that she wasn't sobbing talking about this right now, or that she didn't want to. She should still want to right?

"An envelope was found near…" he shoots a look at Adora, then back to her. "...the scene…" He was going to say 'body', wasn't he? "...with your name on it. Do you know anything about it?"

She thinks for a moment. Stace had never given her so much as a check in an envelope. "No, I have no idea what it would be."

"Inside is a note, handwritten on what looks like a scrap piece of paper. It says…" The man looks down at a notepad. "...'I, Charlotte Rene Burns, give this all to Catra Mendoza.'" He looked back up at her.

It was good she was still sitting, because that probably would have knocked her down. Charlotte. Her name was Charlotte. Catra still remembered her first week there -she'd come off stage and Stace congratulated her on a wonderful performance. After work they stayed late and went to a bar. By the end of the night, Catra formally introduced herself and Stace was almost...disappointed. She said, "What you're running from can't be too bad, otherwise you wouldn't be spreading your real name around so easily." Catra asked what she was running from and she simply said, "Something bad enough to never use my real name. Take one from me, honey. If you really don't wanna be found, you just pick a new name and stick to it. Don't let the old one slip for nobody." Nobody. But here -after all this time -she finally knew her name. Charlotte. It suited her. Or maybe it suited a younger, more naive version of her. Stace still felt right. She started crying again and she hated it -hated how the two men were watching her. It just confirmed how she'd been feeling -pitiful.

"No." She sniffed. "I have no idea what it could be." But it sounded like something you'd say in a will. It sounded like she knew something bad was going to happen, knew she was going to die. Goddammit Stace.

"It's got some numbers and a key taped to it."

Catra put her face in her hands. “I don’t know.” What was she trying to give her? WHY was she trying to give her something? Did she really know she was going to die? So she, just what, scribbled whatever she could down on a scrap of paper? Jesus…

“It’s okay…” Fuck you. How is this okay? “I’m sorry. I know...I mean, I appreciate you answering my questions. We’re going to put a stop to this.” Catra set her jaw and was able to raise her teary eyes to meet his sullen gaze -at least he really did look sorry.

“What does it take to get somebody the death penalty?”

The room goes fairly quiet. “Well…”

“If we can prove that he’s not crazy, and he’s still a danger to society, will they put him on death row?”

. “Catra…” Adora is asking her to put her anger away with that tone of voice, but she won’t. It won’t work. Her fury has one target.

She continues to hold his gaze. “Will they?”

“I don’t know. But I do know that we’re gonna catch this sonofabitch, and he’ll get what’s coming to him. He’ll be held responsible.”

Before the two men close the door behind them, King turns one last time. “I promise.” His voice is echoed by Adora’s right next to her. She says it too. She doesn’t know if she believes them or not, but what else can she do? She can’t really go on thinking that this very real bad guy gets away free. Catra’s not sure what exactly she’s supposed to be feeling, but there’s a lot of it. She’s really not sure what to do with herself. Adora seems like she’s not really sure either. She just had to do something to get rid of this feeling of being useless, of being scared and weak. She climbs back into bed with Adora and they take a nap for a while -or, at least, she does. Sleep could fix just about everything because there was

nothing in sleep -no voices or fears or grayscale colors to sift through, just quiet.

Eventually the nurse comes in and removes the leads from Adora's chest and she's allowed to get up and stretch gently and walk around. Catra laughs when she turns around and finds Adora naked under the robe. Seeing Adora's ass was totally sexy, but she looked a little like an old person wearing assless chaps in that thing. Well...not really -she could make anything look good, but it was still funny. Still, it was kind of...exciting to know that Adora had nothing on under that thing. How had she not noticed sooner?

Once the nurse leaves, Catra lays back down on the bed and gives Adora the finger motion to 'come-here'. Adora shakes her head. "I've been laying in that bed for like, 42 hours straight. I NEED to stand and be a little active."

The brunette gets on her knees and does her best pout that's still almost casual enough to not be really pouting -just a gentle push in the right direction, really -HER direction. "That's fine. I was just thinking maybe you'd want to try being active while laying down." She did like the idea. She'd never had sex in a hospital before. Did that count as being 'in public'? That would be a new one for their list...

Adora raises her eyebrows. "Catra, I'm not supposed to do anything strenuous for like two weeks, minimum."

Catra practically purrs. "Who says you have to do anything strenuous?" Gotcha. Adora blushes. "You can just lie here and let me do all the work."

Adora had picked a spot across the room to hide her eyes at."They said my heart rate isn't supposed to go above 115 for at least six days. I...can't hardly kiss you without that happening, apparently." UGGGGH. She's so cute. I love her. I love her, I love her, I love her.

“Well we won’t know until we try, will we?” Just say yes. It’ll be quick -I promise.

Adora grabs the back of her neck with her free hand, blushing furiously. “You really wanna do that here?”

“Why not? You always did like to play doctor. It’s your turn to be the patient for once. You can handle that, can’t you?” She bites her lip, knowing full well the blonde is about to give in.

Adora takes a few steps closer and Catra rises up on her knees so they’re almost the same height, her heart picking up the pace a little. Holy shit...are we really going to have sex in a hospital room? This is kind of hot. She grabs Adora’s robe, but doesn’t pull for fear of causing her any pain. I just want to make her feel good. She’s been through so much...Adora raises her good hand to gently grab the back of Catra’s neck and the touch is electric. The way her fingers press the skin there just a little bit in that sort of possessive way, how she holds her close -she is everything. Then Adora’s tongue is rolling over Catra’s still slightly swollen lower lip and dancing with hers. And then-

Then the door flies open and there are footsteps.

“Oh, shit!”

“Whoaaaaa.” They fly apart, which Catra knows hurts Adora -she hears the hiss of breath she lets out. It’s -

A tall, darker-skinned woman with her hair up in a big bun, and a sandy-brown-haired man in a button-down shirt and slacks. Lonnie. Lonnie and...Kyle? Of fucking course it was Lonnie and Kyle walking in on them. But...oh shit...Lonnie and Kyle were here! Catra was frozen in place.

“Well, Mom said you were here.” Uh oh. Lonnie didn’t seem thrilled to see her. “‘Dora, I’m glad to see you’ve still got your usual energy.” The way she said ‘energy’ actually frazzled her a little bit. “When I heard you got shot, I was worried, but you must be fine if you can still-”

“Heyyy! It’s great to see you guys too! Kyle, you came all the way out here just for this?” Adora was clearly feeling the same way she was. Like...how the hell are we going to explain this?

The young man Catra was still failing to recognize as Kyle shoved his hands in his pockets -not nervously anymore, like he used to, but it was still definitely Kyle. “Yesterday was the last day on set, so I had time, but even if I didn’t, you know I’d still be here.”

“Yeah.”

God. They were so grown up. Lonnie was still taller by a couple inches, and it looked like she was still pretty active. Her skin looked amazing and she was just so...so...adult. And Kyle! Fucking KYLE! He was a few inches taller than Catra now, his hair had gotten darker -or maybe he dyed it -he ditched the glasses, he had an actual sense of style now, and he had...muscles?! Since when?! She watched, still unsure as to what she could possibly say right now, as they each stepped forward to hug Adora.

Seeing them together now was...wow. Seven years. She left them alone for seven years and they all grew up together and she missed it. Fuck.

Kyle stepped towards her with that goofy, charming grin. “It’s good to see you, Catra.” He held out his arms like he was going to hug her. For a moment, she didn’t know if she was going to let him -but she did. And she immediately regretted it. “It’s been too long.” She couldn’t stop her eyes from welling up again. It really, really had been. As they step away, she wipes the tears away, hoping that nobody sees.

“Yeah, it has. I’m sorry.”

Lonnie continued to appraise her from a distance. Finally, something in her eyes softened and she held up her arms too. “...glad you’re here with her now.” Oh God. Acceptance was such a bitch. Why was this family so fucking nice? She doesn’t wait for Lonnie to let go before she wipes a tear from her cheek behind

her back. Catra can feel Adora watching them. This was probably really emotional for her too...When she finally does let go, Lonnie just gives her this look, like...like how Razz looks at her. "We've all got our shit." That's it -that's all she says, and she says it with her chip-shouldered Lonnie way, but Catra knows exactly what it means -'I forgive you'. And it's. Too. Much. Razz taught them all too well.

But before her eyes even have time to produce more tears, she continues. "So are you two back together, or what?" Crickets. "I know you two aren't just fuckin' around without it meaning SOMETHING." Catra and Adora both blink at them. "I swear, if you try to tell me you were 'arguing'-" If by chance they ever did happen to leave the door unlocked and got barged in on, they often got away with saying they got into an argument, which then snowballed into a tussle. Well..apparently they DIDN'T get away with that excuse. Adora's cheeks, and even her ears, are bright pink.

"We were…" She's struggling.

"Ohhhh, let me guess. You were playing doctor, only you didn't have a thermometer, so you just conveniently used Catra's tongue instead?"

Catra almost laughed out loud. What are the odds? If only she'd been there moments before. "That's pretty accurate, yeah."

"Catra!" Adora was looking at her, open-mouthed and mortified.

She shrugged. "What?! They totally caught us this time. There's no point in trying to hide it."

Kyle shrugged. "Why would you try and hide it anyways? It's not like we didn't already know."

"You did?"

"Hell yeah. And what do you mean, THIS time?" Lonnie scoffed. "Hah. Are you serious?" She scrunched her face and raised her

voice. “Ooohhh, Adoraaa, spank me!” They both gasped. Adora hid her face behind her hands and Catra covered her open mouth. It didn’t happen very often but now her face was on fire. “Yeah, try listening to that while you’re trying to sleep, twice a week, and NOT know exactly what’s going on.”

“Ohhhhmhyyghhhhd.” Adora’s muffled voice came through her hands. If anyone should be embarrassed here, it was Catra -and she was.

Lonnie turned to Kyle with arms crossed over her chest. “What was it that one time they tried to tell us it was?”

Kyle pursed his lips and raised his eyebrows, rocking back and forth on his heels. “Slapjack. Yup. Yeah.”

“Tsh. Slapjack. Catra, when have you literally EV-ER, WILLINGLY played a game of cards in your life?” She was still just...so...how to recover from that. “Nah, the only thing she was slapping was that ass. I always knew you were a bottom.”

“Excuse me?” She was only half, serious. It was kind of true.

“It’s okay, Catra.” Kyle gave a broad smile. “Me too.” She’d never really noticed how much he and Lonnie did look alike until now.

“Well we all knew that.” They all laughed -a sound she hasn’t heard in so long, except for the rare and occasional memory in a dream of their childhood together. This felt familiar. This felt like she could belong here again. In spite of herself, and in spite of everything that’s happening around them, she feels hopeful.

Learning the Difference

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora FINALLY talk about why Catra left.

Chapter Notes

You guys...you have no idea how long I've been planning this moment...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Kyle and Lonnie stayed for a few hours and then headed back to Razz's place to stay the night. It was amazing to see them around Catra -it was something Adora didn't think she'd ever get to have again. There were a few tense moments where the conversation was strained -namely with Lonnie. Even the most direct conflict stayed civil though, which she was thankful for. Adora felt guilty though -selfish almost. She knew that Lonnie and Kyle were upset when Catra left. Lonnie was angry, but she'd only ever expressed anger on Adora's behalf -which, now she understood more fully, given how much they really knew -but it was clear now that she had some resentment stemming from her own feelings towards Catra. "Yeah, well...ghost me once, shame on me. Ghost me twice…"

Catra furrowed her eyebrows. "Look, I know that when-"

Lonnie's hard exterior held firm, but her words relayed pain. "All I'm saying is: we're supposed to be family. And you just up and left without saying goodbye. Poof, gone."

Catra nods. "I know."

The conversation was redirected and the tension resolved naturally shortly thereafter. Now Adora's happy it's just the two of them. Somehow she feels like she's had enough social interaction today and she's ready to have some peace -that's what time with

Catra was like, and it made no sense. Even though she herself was chaos -beautiful, alluring chaos -when Adora was with her, she felt calm, reacharged.

“Ew.” The brunette has her arm near her head. “Why didn’t you tell me I smelled so bad?”

Adora shrugs. “Because you don’t smell bad.”

“Uh. I’m pretty sure I do. Have you smelled this?” She’s pointing to her armpit.

“No, but I will. C’mere.” She’s close enough that Adora can grab her shirt and pull her in. It causes pain in her abdomen and around her ribs in the back which she ignores.

“Gross, no.” Adora leans down to sniff. “Adora, stop!” Catra’s laughing and the sound fills her with warmth just as much as her scent does. It just smells like her skin -soft, warm. “Ew, freak.” She remembers the last time she did this to make Catra laugh. It was after one of Catra’s practices -she’d had a rough week. Adora stayed to watch practice and then she drove Catra home, pulled her in close like this, got her laughing until she cried happy tears. Nothing has changed. But somewhere, from the back of her mind, a voice warns: you don’t know that.

She’s missed seven full years of Catra’s life -seven years where she didn’t get to hear about what she did throughout the day, what she did. That’s insane. She should feel like she doesn’t know Catra at all, but it’s just not true. But she still wants to know everything -her hobbies, what her relationship with dance is like now that it’s technically her job, if she’s even talked to her parents at all, if she’s been...seeing other people. On second thought. No...I don’t really want to know.

“What was that?” Catra is watching her, somewhat concerned. “What just happened?”

Adora gives a half smile. “Nothing…”

“That’s not nothing. You totally just flipped a switch.” Damn. Sometimes she hated how expressive she was. “You’re making a face.”

Adora sighed heavily. “I guess I just...have...a lot of questions.”

She watches Catra sort of stumble around in her head a little bit, sees the gears working. Then her beautiful eyes are set and she looks determined -an expression that she rarely saw shape those features. “Well...I have time. We’re going to be here a while.”

Adora holds her stare. “Really?” Maybe Catra really had matured since she’s been away…

“I...owe you a lot of answers.” Adora sat down on the edge of the bed and Catra sat in the chair across from it. Okay. If Catra was really willing to do this now, then... so was she.

“Okay…” Then...she should just jump right in, right? “I called you...a lot.” Catra’s resolve immediately crumbled. Apparently these weren’t the kinds of questions she was expecting. “I messaged you and left, albeit, some very embarrassing voicemails under the influence...why didn’t you answer...ANY of it? I mean...none of it.” It hurt. Bad. “Eventually I just...I dunno, I gave up. I thought…” Goddammit. Wow. She definitely thought she was more okay than she was. The wave of emotion that just crashed over her head was tightening her vocal cords to a painful degree. She clears her throat. Now would be a good time for Catra to have some sort of outburst. Some sort of fit of anger or annoyance or something, so she wouldn’t have to say this out loud. “I thought that if we -if I meant something to you, you could’ve at least said SOMETHING. Anything. Ever.”

She brings her eyes up from the floor to steal a glance at Catra, who is holding back tears and looking at the ceiling, biting her lip. “I never...it wasn’t like that. I…”

“How was it not like that, Catra?” Her throat constricted again at the name and she feels a bit...unstable. I didn’t know I was still so

upset…

A single tear falls down the brunette's proud cheek and she wipes it quickly, still looking at the ceiling. Her voice is strained too and what she says is quiet. "I didn't want to be cruel."

The words insight flames. She can see Catra is struggling and this has to be hard for her too, but...just...what the fuck? Adora emphasizes every syllable. "You didn't want to be CRUEL?" Now she's going to cry -she's immeasurably frustrated and confused. "How is what happened NOT cruel, Catra? I tell you that I think I love you and you dismiss me like it's nothing, like there's nothing there, and then you're just gone from my life in the blink of an eye. How is that NOT CRUEL? I had no closure! None!"

"It was easier, okay?"

"EASIER? HOW was that easier? Easier for who?"

"For both of us!" Catra meets her gaze for the first time since the conversation started and Adora see's pain behind her tears but she's just so angry.

"How could that possibly have been easier for BOTH of us, Catra? Last time I checked, I was miserable, so please, explain it to me because I just don't get it." Now they were both crying and Adora hated that she sounded aggressive right now but apparently there were flood gates that had been opened and now that it was happening, she couldn't stop it.

"You're really going to tell me that it would have been just fine if I was texting you on the daily like, 'hey, guess what I did today?' Like that wouldn't have been worse?"

"YES!"

Catra shook her head, looking like a defiant child. "No. Because then you would be asking me why, and-"

"Yeah, God forbid we have a conversation-"

They were getting louder. “I couldn’t lie, Adora!”

Her mind was racing a mile a minute, only to go in circles and end up stranded in an unknown place. Catra’s logic made zero sense. “Then God forbid you tell the fucking truth!” Catra lets out a frustrated whimper and Adora feels like she’s about to let out a frustrated scream. “And, lie about what? What, a-about me? If you didn’t feel the same way, Catra you could have just said so - you didn’t need to fucking cut us all out. I could have been fine. I would’ve gotten over it -eventually.” That’s a lie. “I-”

Catra’s shaking her head. “Jesus, fuck -no! Not like that. I didn’t mean-” She closes her eyes tightly for a second.

“Whatever it was that was under your skin, we could have talked about it. I would have understood, Catra. If you had told me you needed to get away, I would have understood. I could have supported you, just as a friend, if that’s what you wanted. Even if you didn’t want to be with me like-”

“That’s exactly why I had to go. That. Right there.”

AHHHHH. “WHAT?! What is?!” PLEASE.

Catra threw her hands up. “You were going to give up EVERYTHING you worked SO goddamn hard for your whole life,” Catra’s voice was cutting in and out. Her throat probably hurt too. “...all throughout school, for ME.” What? “And you’re s-so fucking stupid that you would’ve done it without blinking an eye. I know you would have.”

“What are you talking about?”

“You were going to wait for me. You were going to give up the scholarship of a lifetime to go to a nice-ass school that YOU WANTED to go to, to stay and watch me fucking barely make it out of high school. I was keeping you back!” Click. “Everybody knew it. I-” Unbelievable. Abso-fucking-lutely, unbeleivable.

Adora was livid. Adora was beside herself. They had done it again. The same problem. The same conversation. They should have just talked. SHE should have just talked. “Are you serious?” Catra crossed her arms over her chest, widening her eyes as the only response. “Are you fucking serious? Do you have ANY idea how infuriating that is?” Catra opened her mouth but Adora cut her off. “What I WANTED, was you, Catra. I wanted you. And you didn’t even give me -didn’t give US -a fucking chance because you were so consumed by your own goddamn insecurities.” The look that flashed across her face made it clear that Catra had never given thought to it like that, which made it an even harder pill to swallow.

“Adora-”

“No. You’re not- you’re not hearing me, Catra -you’re not LISTENING. Listen. To the words I’m saying...” Her voice gives out completely. The ‘Please’ at the end comes out as nothing more than a whisper. So she redoubles her efforts to speak clearly. “I. WANTED. YOU. And you didn’t LISTEN, because in your mind, I was either ignorant of MY OWN FEELINGS, or stupid for having them, right? YOU put words -somebody ELSE’s words, YOUR own insecure words - in MY mouth. That’s bullshit. That’s so beyond unfair. You didn’t even give me a choice. AND you didn’t even give me a chance to explain myself.”

She let out a dry laugh of frustration. Catra was visibly shaking, but Adora would say anything to get through to her -if that was even possible. “So there I was, standing there, literally throwing myself at you, and you walked away because you didn’t TRUST me, because YOU didn’t think you were worth it, not me. I ALWAYS thought you were worth it -worth anything, EVERYTHING. And that really, really fucking sucks.” She lets out a shuddering sigh, wiping her face and looking away. She can’t look at Catra when she says this. It hurts. She feels every word. “You aren’t unlovable, Catra. It’s just that you don’t LET people love you. There’s a difference, but I can’t learn that lesson for you.” Catra turns away from her, still shaking and she feels guilty. “I”ll...I’ll still be here when you figure that out…” She reaches a

hand out to touch her shoulder but Catra steps away. And then she simply walks out the door.

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The question catches her off guard -not because she wasn't expecting to have this conversation, but because she wasn't expecting them to jump right in. Over the last few days she had imagined this conversation transitioning smoothly from light to dark. And when she hears Adora say, 'If I meant something to you…' she'd rather die than have this conversation right now, like this. All she could think was: well, you wanted to be the bad guy, right? Good job. You did it. You hurt her.

"I never…" meant for it to seem that way. "it wasn't like that. I…" couldn't tell you the truth.

"How was it not like that, Catra?" Adora seemed really angry, and she had a right to be...but still...

She wipes a tear that escaped, eyes glued to the ceiling. I had to do it. If I had talked to you afterwards it just would have given you hope that I was coming back. It would have given ME hope. I couldn't do that to us. Her voice is strained too and what she says is quiet. "I didn't want to be cruel."

"You didn't want to be CRUEL?" Apparently that was the wrong thing to say -just like what she did was the wrong thing to do. She just couldn't ever get it right. "How is what happened NOT cruel, Catra?" I'm sorry Adora. "I tell you that I think I love you and you dismiss me like it's nothing, like there's nothing there, and then you're just gone from my life in the blink of an eye. How is that NOT CRUEL? I had no closure! None!"

The excuse is blurted out before she can stop it -a defense mechanism. "It was easier, okay?"

"EASIER? HOW was that easier? Easier for who?" Adora is raising her voice and it makes Catra feel small. Adora never raises her

voice. She raises hers right back to compensate.

“For both of us!”

“How could that possibly have been easier for BOTH of us, Catra? Last time I checked, I was miserable, so please, explain it to me because I just don’t get it.” Now they were both crying and Catra could hear the pain in her voice -she remembers what Glimmer said about when they first met, that Adora didn’t think she was worth it...fuck. I messed up. I messed up so fucking bad. But she’s still fighting. She did what she thought was right in the moment -she was doing it for Adora!

“You’re really going to tell me that it would have been just fine if I was texting you on the daily like, ‘hey, guess what I did today?’ Like that wouldn’t have been worse?”

“YES!” It shocks her.

Catra shook her head, looking like a defiant child. “No. Because then you would be asking me why, and-” I couldn’t take that. I couldn’t tell you I loved you back because that would have sealed your fate but I also couldn’t-

“Yeah, God forbid we have a conversation-”

Catra squeezes her eyes tightly shut. “I couldn’t lie, Adora!” I couldn’t tell you I didn’t love you back. You would have known.

“Then God forbid you tell the fucking truth!” Catra lets out a frustrated whimper, feeling trapped. “And, lie about what? What, a-about me?” Catra sees deep into those blue eyes and knows she said something wrong again. “If you didn’t feel the same way, Catra you could have just said so -you didn’t need to fucking cut us all out.” Adora looks so defeated. “I could have been fine. I would’ve gotten over it -eventually. I-”

Catra’s shaking her head. “Jesus, fuck -no! Not like that. I didn’t mean-” She closes her eyes again, trying to find a way to recover, to make her understand.

“Whatever it was that was under your skin, we could have talked about it. I would have understood, Catra.” I know you would have. I know! “If you had told me you needed to get away, I would have understood. I could have supported you, just as a friend, if that’s what you wanted. Even if you didn’t want to be with me like-”

“That’s exactly why I had to go. That. Right there.” Your self-sacrificial bullshit.

“WHAT?! What is?!”

Catra threw her hands up. “You were going to give up EVERYTHING you worked SO goddamn hard for your whole life,” Catra’s voice was cutting in and out, throat burning “...all throughout school, for ME. And you’re s-so fucking stupid that you would’ve done it without blinking an eye. I know you would have.”

“What are you talking about?” How could she not get it?

“You were going to wait for me. You were going to give up the scholarship of a lifetime to go to a nice-ass school that YOU WANTED to go to, to stay and watch me fucking…” Flounder. Fail. “...barely make it out of high school. I was keeping you back! Everybody knew it. I-”

Adora’s voice took on a very calm tone, despite the emotions burning into Catra’s skin from her eyes. “Are you serious?” Catra crossed her arms over her chest, widening her eyes as the only response. “Are you fucking serious? Do you have ANY idea how infuriating that is?” Catra opened her mouth but Adora cut her off. “What I WANTED, was you, Catra.” Bam. The words hit her like a ton of bricks. “I wanted you. And you didn’t even give me -didn’t give US -a fucking chance because you were so consumed by your own goddamn insecurities.” I...I...

“Adora-”

“No. You’re not- you’re not hearing me, Catra -you’re not LISTENING.” I’m trying… “Listen. To the words I’m saying...” Her

voice gives out completely. The 'Please' at the end comes out as nothing more than a whisper and it disintegrates the little shreds of Catra's heart that are lying on the floor. "I. WANTED. YOU. And you didn't LISTEN, because in your mind, I was either ignorant of MY OWN FEELINGS, or stupid for having them, right?" Well… when you put it like that... "YOU put words -somebody ELSE's words, YOUR own insecure words - in MY mouth. That's bullshit. That's so beyond unfair. You didn't even give me a choice. AND you didn't even give me a chance to explain myself."

She let out a dry laugh of frustration, a sound that rattled Catra's bones. Adora was so upset -and she had every right to be -but...it made her feel cold. She couldn't fix this. "So there I was, standing there, literally throwing myself at you, and you walked away because you didn't TRUST me…" I did trust you! I do trust you! "...because YOU didn't think you were worth it, not me." Because I WASN'T! Because I'm...I'm not...

"I ALWAYS thought you were worth it -worth anything, EVERYTHING. And that really, really fucking sucks." She lets out a shuddering sigh, wiping her face and looking away. Her voice is softened but somehow the words cut worse than anything else she's said in anger. "You aren't unlovable, Catra." Stop. Stop talking. "It's just that you don't LET people love you. There's a difference…" Adora, please… "but I can't learn that lesson for you." Catra turns away -she has to turn away. "I"ll...I'll still be here when you figure that out…"

Catra gets out of the room as fast as her body will carry her. Then she's blindly moving down corridors and hallways and she can hear somebody screaming somewhere and all she can think is that she would love to switch places with that person. Whatever they were going through had to be less painful than this -less excruciating than this pure sense of agoning regret. She doesn't stop until she's found her way outside in the evening air. God, a cigarette would be great right now if she still smoked. Hell, anything would be great right now. Her pocket buzzes. Adora has sent her a text message. In some kind of bout of masochism, she opens the message: I'm sorry.

Jesus Christ, Adora. New tears making their own waterfall paths down her cheeks, she responds.

Don't.

Please don't apologize.

I just needed air.

She thinks nervously for a moment about saying something else, about running again -disappearing. But no.

I'll be back in a few minutes.

There. Now she has to go back. She's bound -committed. And as she stares at the screen, she realizes this is the first time seven years that she's responded to Adora's text messages. She hopes Adora will understand what it means. I'm here to accept responsibility for my actions. 'You aren't unlovable, Catra...you don't let people love you. There's a difference.' Goddammit.

She starts to type: 'you're right', but deletes it. I'm going to tell her that in person. She leans over the cold railing for a few more minutes, getting her breathing under control, before walking back in through the building -passed the receptionist desk and passed people who were looking at her funny, probably thinking somebody died, when really she was just being a pathetic, sniveling child. The truth hurt like a bitch, but Adora deserved that at least. She opens the door feeling...NOT confident, no, but at the very least, she has the willpower to say what needs to be said. As she's taking her first steps in, she starts to form the words, "You're ri-" oof!
Adora's body sort of slams into hers, wrapping around her. Her hands clutch at the fabric of her shirt -even the fingers sticking out of the cast on the right. The blonde has buried her still-wet face in Catra's neck. The heartbreak in her voice is too much to handle. "Stay. Please." And just like that, it occurs to her that she'd left without saying anything in response. Again. GOD. DAMMIT. She's so fucking stupid. WHY couldn't she just figure this

out? It shouldn't be this hard to fucking communicate like a normal person.

"I'm not going anywhere." Now they were both crying again and she felt like the strength she'd found to tell the truth had already waned to an unusable amount. But she couldn't let it. She HAD to do this. This ONE fucking thing -for Adora. "You were right. About everything." Keep going. "There's nothing I can say...to...change things-"

"You don't have to say anything. You're still here." This was torture.

"No-I do. I do have to say it. You deserve--"

Adora pulls away to look at her. "I forgive you, Catra." And she loses control, if she ever had it. She can't take the sincerity and the compassion in those pools of blue -the love that's still there, the love she doesn't deserve. That she maybe never will. But for some fucking reason, Adora feels that way about her, and she wants Adora to get whatever she wants -wants her to be able to choose her path in life. So fuck it. It's happening. Adora holds her close again while she cries openly for who knows how long.

Finally, when she can breathe, Catra tries again. "I should have told you a million times over…" She's searching in Adora's eyes for something -confirmation of some kind that this is really okay, but she can't find it and she can't wait anymore either. "I love you, Adora. I think I always have." Adora beams and it breaks her heart all over again. "I think...I still do." Adora pulls her in again, a hand wrapping around the back of her neck and holding their faces close. "I always will." They kiss -gently, so gently -and it's the same but different. It's like they're free.

Adora sniffles. "I...want to do everything with you."

Catra wipes her cheek on Adora's shoulder, her lips curling into a smile. "I told you, I'm not into foot stuff." They both laugh.

“You know what I mean. I want to take you to restaurants and concerts and parks and I want to show you off to the world.” Catra’s heart feels unbearably full at the thought of having a normal relationship -un-isolated and in plain sight -with Adora. Well...no. Fuck that. They were anything but normal. Their love was extraordinary. The excitement in Adora’s eyes -hell, exuding from her whole body- is reminiscent of her nervous teenage self.

Catra brings back the words. “Adora Ether. Are you asking if I’ll be your girlfriend?”

Adora’s voice starts to strain again. “No.”

“Oh.” There’s a slight disappointment but more than anything she’s curious.

“I’m asking if you’ll go on a date with me-” There’s the blush she was expecting.

“Oh” I’ll take it. I like the sound of that too.

“Because after enough of them, I’m going to ask if you’ll be my wife.” OH. Catra processes for a moment, her breath stuttering.

She’s very careful to make sure Adora knows she’s sincere. “Yes.” She smiles. “I would love to.”

“You’re my person, Catra.”

Chapter End Notes

Did you cry as much as I did?

The Expense of Exit Strategies

Chapter Summary

> Catra gets called in for questioning again and learns a little bit more about Stace's past. Now she has to really process her loss.

Chapter Notes

> Thanks for hanging in there while I move! I promise, I'm not done with this one yet!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was nice to be home again -but then again, not. There was still so much uncertainty in all of this. Would more hitmen be sent to take them out? Was Hordak still trying to take Catra as some sort of sick human prize? Who else was involved on the inside? There were still so many questions that needed to be answered, and none of them came easily. What DID come easily was every second spent with Catra. They fell perfectly into rhythm with one another effortlessly. They were different now than when they were teenagers, but somehow together it was almost the same. Well...better. Catra was trying -REALLY trying to be more open and vulnerable and it was something Adora never knew just how much she needed from her. The more time they spent talking, the more she realized that Catra really had been independent and more mature over the last few years -and she took pride in that.

She'd handled everything that happened so far remarkably well, resilient as ever. Adora knew Catra would be on the receiving end of more police questioning. Given her involvement with the owners, that made sense. However, neither of them expected her to be called into the station -still not under threat of legal penalty, but Adora could tell by the tone of King's voice that it was pressing that she come. So they went together -Adora drove her in Catra's car. When they walk in, people are coming up to ask

how Adora is and show support. Catra seems uncomfortable but she's civil. It occurs to Adora that part of her discomfort could be all the people coping with humor, saying things like, 'Man, close call huh?" Catra had admitted that the thought of Adora dying was more than she could bear, and Adora understood completely.

King sits them down in an interrogation room -the same room Catra had been brought to before, which was nice of them. It wasn't exactly what anyone would call 'comfortable', but at least it wouldn't be totally foreign to her. Still, she seemed on edge, understandably.

"So…" He sets a key on the table with a note in scribbled chicken scratch. "You said you didn't know what this is, correct?" What is it?

He pushes it to Catra and Adora watches her face scrunch in confusion and pain. "I don't." She reaches out to touch the edge of the paper but recoils. "Jesus." Tears well up in her eyes. "I can barely read it."

"Is that what Stace's handwriting normally looks like?" Oh. It's that note.

Catra shakes her head. "No." She's trying to blink tears away, failing. "I think...I think she was scared."

"You think she knew she was in trouble?" Catra nods. "Why?"

A small noise escapes Catra's throat -effort from holding back tears. "Because I t-hink I was on the phone with her right before it happened." WHAT?

Adora puts her hand on the top of the brunette's thigh. "Catra, you never told me that…" That has to feel horrible…

King clicks his pen and starts to take notes. "You were on the phone with her that day?" Adora can tell by the tone of his voice that he's still suspicious of Catra, and that makes her feel on edge.

Catra nods again, wiping her eyes before they leak. “She called me to see...where I was. She wanted to know if I was safe. She wasn’t...she wasn’t being herself though. I asked if she was okay and she just said, just said she was fine and then she had to go. She hung up on me. She never does that.” Jesus, that’s rough…

“I see.” The agent leans back and sighs. “Well, this little baby is the key to a safety deposit box at the local bank just down the street.” He reaches under the table and both Catra and Adora are watching him carefully. He moves quickly and a flash of color and shine is all their eyes catch for a moment. He’s dumped five large ziploc bags full of jewelry onto the table with a heavy-sounding clank of metal on metal. Glittering gold and diamonds, sapphires and rubies, pearls and opals, all in a heap.

Catra looks up at King. “I-I don’t understand. What am I looking at?”

He leans back. “You tell me. She left this for you.”

“WHAT?”

“I read you the note. She was leaving the contents of this safety deposit box for you. Nothing has been apprasied since this is still technically evidence in a murder investigation, but I’m fairly sure it’s all real -probably worth a couple hundred thousand dollars, at least.”

Catra shook her head. “That doesn’t...make any...sense. Where did she GET all of this?”

He shrugged. “I was hoping you could tell me.”

“I don’t know! I don’t know why she would leave it to me! I-” Catra leans forward suddenly. “Wait, I recognize this one.” She’s pointing to a golden chain, heavy with pearls. “Stace had me wear this for a decade performance one time. I asked her where she got it and she said it was some guy trying to buy her affection. She said...she wanted nothing to do with him anymore.” Adora could almost see the memory behind Catra’s eyes. “I asked her if

she was going to keep it and she said yeah. It was...it was her 'exit strategy'. She always said…" Two different colored eyes fill with tears once again. Catra covers her mouth. "She said you always have to have an exit strategy."

"I'm sorry…" King's eyebrows were fallen -he really did look sorry. At least he believed her that Catra had nothing to do with the murder of her employers. Clearly she was grief-stricken. "It was probably her husband she was talking about. Some big-wig oil driller down south. He owns several offshore rigs. Said she took off one day and never came back. We found the missing persons report from nearly fifteen years ago."

Catra just sat there chewing her lip, looking almost… angry? What was she angry about? What was she thinking?

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That's it. He's the one. He's what Stace had run away from -rat bastard. Catra just knew it. She hated him already for whatever it was that he did to her. Goddamn you. The man on the other side of the table asks her a few more questions about the jewels and if she heard anything else while she was on the phone with Stace. She wracks her brain trying to remember, but those details are already lost to misattribution and time. Her answers are short. She's wondering what Stace's husband looks like, what he sounds like, what his favorite drink is so she can…

Adora thanks people on the way out and they drive home almost in silence, which Catra's thankful for. Adora just knows when she needs space -she's so perfect. The last week and a half with her has been...the best, most colorful time of her life since before she ran away. In hindsight, she has no idea why she did it. Adora is everything she could ever have asked for and then some. The thought of someday marrying her -of the real proposal, no matter who does it for whom -was too good to be true. Right now, they were just 'getting to know each other again', which was bullshit. They were spending quality time together, sure, but the reality

was that they still knew even the little details about each other, the way one would expect from two people who loved each other for years.

Some part of her was grateful that they were on the same page with waiting until this was all over. Catra still hadn't fully processed things -she knew it would take time. But all this shit about Stace today...she just felt cold all over. Stace knew. She KNEW she was going to die. Her exit strategy was just to try to help Catra as much as she could before she went and that broke her heart. They were supposed to get away TOGETHER, and now...now life moves on, right? It always does.

When they get back to the house, Adora goes to put some dinner together and the cold takes over the second she leaves the room, chilling her bones and weighing her down. She turns the shower on, suddenly too tired to remove her clothes. She steps in and stands under the water, thankful that it's working -mostly -heating her icy core from the outside, keeping her at a bearable temperature. She curls up under the stream on the floor, hugging her knees to her chest.

If Catra hadn't run away -if she'd stayed -maybe Stace would have been fine. Maybe they both would have been fine. She could have used the money from the jewelry to get away -that was surely her plan in keeping them. That's what she said. "Get rid of it? Why the hell would I get rid of this fancy-ass necklace when I can keep it for a needier time? You never know when this could come in handy." Remembering the timbre of her voice only serves to make Catra feel worse. She hears the haunting last words, how all her usual confidence had left with the single, definite CLICK of the phone. "I've gotta go." That could have been it, right there. They could have been standing behind her, arms out and ready. Jesus Christ.

"Catra?"

Adora's concerned voice rings out from the other room, but Catra doesn't look up. She's too busy imagining the struggle -the sound

of gasps. “Catra?” Adora is in the doorway, looking down at her.

She lifts her eyes, feeling the water against the back of her head, a single small stream running down her nose. She probably looks crazy. “I can’t get warm.” Adora is taking off her shirt and throwing her pants on the floor. Then she’s in the shower holding Catra and that simple act alone does more to ease her shivering than the water ever could. Adora holds Catra so close to her, and they rock gently back and forth ever so slightly as Catra cries. But she’s warmer now. Adora has always been able to do this -makes her feel better, distracts her, makes her forget whatever it is causing her anguish.

Catra raises her eyes to meet pools of vibrant blue. They’re nothing like the other color blue she feels like she's drowning in, all dingy-purple and reddish around the edges, sliding in and out of grayscale. Adora’s eyes hold all the same love Catra feels from her touch, the same warmth. The brunette’s eyes travel down to where her finger now rests close to Adora’s lower lip. She glances back up to her eyes one more time before moving in to put their lips together. It’s a soft touch at first, and then Catra presses herself into it. Adora is the one to pull away, wary. “Catra…”

There’s something in her stare that drives Catra mad. Not sadness -pity. Adora feels sorry for her right now and she hates it. But she doesn’t have enough mental energy to care right now. She just wants Adora to distract her. “Please…” Adora’s hand is still holding her firmly, not pushing her away but also not pulling her in either. “Make me forget.”

And then Adora seems to understand. "Catra, I..." She gives one more glance to ask Catra if she’s sure and the brunette holds her gaze to answer, pleading with her eyes. With that, the rest of her clothes come off quickly and Adora is everywhere, just like Catra needs her to be -holding her, surrounding her, in her. The perfect distraction. The perfect everything. They’re far from graceful, trying to keep water out of their eyes and open mouths, but this doesn’t need to be graceful. It just needs to work -and it does. As her pleasure builds, the blurry muddled colors become prettier

patterns that she’d much rather experience, punctuated by every loving word that comes from Adora’s lips against her neck. When Catra finally lets go, body stuttering and out of her control under the false heat of the water, she feels new. She knows as long as she’s with Adora, she can handle anything.

The next day, they get news that Huntara Thornbrrush as pleaded guilty to two counts of murder and faces a minimum of 20 years in prison with no bail. Adora explains that means she won’t go to trial and Catra is livid. She wants to look her in the eye. She wants that woman -that murderer- to know how hated she is. But once again, this world seems to have proved her childhood fears right: the only justice in this world is the justice you create. And that was shitty.

Chapter End Notes

> Sorry this is so short guys! I think that the next one or two will be pretty short, and then they'll get a bit longer again for a few more after that. My goal is to at least get to 10 chapters <3

Moving Forward

Chapter Summary

Adora's POV as time passes post-hospital

Chapter Notes

Sorry for the long break! LIFE. GOT. CRAZY. I moved, I started classes again, I started working more, and I got a new car. Yay! But also...what day of the week is it??? Who knows? Not me!

I'd meant for this to be a bit longer, but I don't think I'll finish in time and I reaaaaaally wanted to post by tonight. SO. Here you go: small update. Things will be slow as we wind down to a close :')

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It took another two and half weeks of digging and hassling the connection of a connection for information. Adora has turned an entire wall in her room into a map of sorts. She's on the phone with different people every day even though she's supposed to still be off the case, working to find a way to get to Hordak. Two local government officials and one congressman have been identified in their ties to the prostitution ring as 'customers'. More would no doubt be exposed down the line for involvement in some way, shape, or form. Politicians always seemed to have dirt SOMEWHERE -they were just smart enough not to leave it on their hands. The three all had court appearances within a week of each other. The two local officials were convicted after pleading guilty to the charges, and the congressman had a trial in a month. No doubt his lawyers would try to handle things behind closed doors in hushed tones, but at this point there was no way to keep the media out of it. Good.

It was a small price to pay for the hundreds of lives these kinds of people have ruined -families torn apart, children scarred, women

murdered. Some of the teenagers they'd recovered and sent to state-funded rehabilitation facilities -which were certainly no vacation -were no more than seventeen. They were no older than Catra when she had left. Whenever Adora thinks about that she loses her appetite for nearly a whole day. To think of what could have happened when she ran away years ago, or really any day since then...She can't.

Catra had been living on the edge of this lifestyle -every time she'd flipped the coin she just happened to land on the side with the glitz and glam of a show, but her luck would have eventually run out -clearly! Adora was just happy Catra had been so...well...so willing to give it all up, as terrible as that sounds. Not the dancing, of course -never the dancing. Adora knew she enjoyed stripping because of the performance aspect of it, and she would never ask Catra to quit something she truly, intrinsically enjoyed, but she couldn't stand the thought of Catra being objectified and treated like a toy on a daily basis. She wanted Catra to find a job where she was respected for her physical prowess, yes, but also her intellect and her wit and her people skills -which she really DID have when she wanted. So when the club closed without the respective owners to run it, Adora was glad, albeit still very sad on her girlfriend's behalf. Over the next few weeks, it became clear that Catra had indeed been very close with Stace. Adora went through her own stages of grief -for Catra, for the situation, and for other victims involved in general -but watching Catra struggle was something else. Some days she was just angry, others she was depressed. She seemed like she didn't know what to do with herself, and Adora gave what felt like all of her excess energy to lifting Catra's spirits in any way she could. Thankfully, it helped to lift her own mood too.

As it turns out, constantly banging your forehead into a brick wall was exhausting. Adora felt like she was utterly useless. She wasn't supposed to spend time at the precinct until she was off medical leave, she wasn't supposed to dig into people's lives for potential connection, and she wasn't supposed to be contacting anyone. But how could she not when it was practically all she could think about? How could she stop herself from reaching out to the family

of a young woman found four states away after she "ran away" from home six years ago? How could she stop herself from attending the few and far between trials of people convicted of molesting these children just to see for herself that they would be put away? And how could she stop herself from being consumed by anger and frustration when the punishment was too lenient? It felt like no matter what she did, or what she didn't do, it wasn't enough. Not enough time, not enough difference made. She couldn't help but feel partially responsible, even though she knew it was really just the flawed system in which she worked. Then again, aren't people like her responsible for allowing it to be that way? She hated it. The list of evil to be vanquished from this world was never ending.

Having Catra around helped -a lot. Despite her own emotional turmoil, Catra seemed to be in tune with Adora's mind, and she was able to support her in ways she didn't even know she needed until it happened. The other night, after another bout of silence from her partners -which meant they hadn't been able to get anything new -Adora had somewhat spiraled. Catra just stared at her until she stopped talking herself in circles, then dragged her upstairs and quite literally shoved her into the bath before joining her. Glimmer and Bow always told her to do things for herself and to take time to relax, but Catra MADE her do it -either by literally pushing her into it, or by teasing her into submission. Both methods were very effective in shocking her back to the reality that she was her own person with her own life and her own needs.

And she needed Catra. They were so quick to come together again, as if they were really just two parts of the same whole. It only made sense that they should live together. Catra moved in with Adora two and a half weeks after she got out of the hospital. The notion of Adora moving in with Catra was thrown off the table pretty quickly -it was on the wrong side of town from Adora's work when she inevitably went back, plus Catra didn't really like it as much as she had spent the last seven years telling herself she did. She admitted that it felt...empty despite the nice furniture and aesthetic. But Catra was used to being on her own and doing

what she wanted, when she wanted to do it. Adora didn’t think she would be okay living with another couple, but she was quickly proven wrong. Catra was thrilled at having two more people to tease and badger -in her playful way, of course, with the exception of certain days of the month when she could be moody. Glimmer and Bow handed her very well -knew when to call her on her bullshit and when to play along to spare her pride. Adora couldn't have been more content. If only she could go back to work...

Considering the crime, the congressman -unsurprisingly -got off with the equivalent of a slap on the wrist, but Adora thought, at least his reputation was ruined and he certainly won’t be going for reelection -or any election for that matter. By the end of the trial, they were able to provide evidence, as circumstantial as it may be, against at least ten more people -still small time. Little by little, they’ve been plucking away at the web these people have woven to protect themselves. It seemed like every other week, another body turned up around the outskirts of the city - no doubt Hordak getting nervous.

It was maddening to have next to nothing on this man. It seemed like there was some “magic” trick, an illusory piece they were missing. She felt like she was running through a maze that only had dead-ends, and the only true way out was to dig under a wall. Only there was no such way of cheating life like that -they were either going to come up with solid proof of his identity and influence in this ring, or they weren’t.

And then it happened. What might have been a miracle fell from the sky, right into their laps. Who should stroll casually right on into the precinct but Double Trouble. Special Agent King spent two hours with them and a lawyer in a room trying to negotiate. When he told Adora that, she nearly threw the phone -that slimy little-...She’d meant what she said about only giving them one single chance, but at least they provided good intel. Supposedly. Double Trouble provided them with a real name, addresses -plural -of mansion homes, copies of text messages, emails, and several voice recordings of Hordak in business, talking both with

prostitutes and Johns alike. Apparently he was just the procurer, not that that was any better. At any rate, they could go straight for him with this and charge him with pandering -so long as this evidence held up and Double Trouble testified. They would move forward from here.

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you for all of the awesome support, and the comments, and the questions, and the kudos. This fic has been such a wild ride and I love that people are so invested - that's rad. There will be at least two more chapters :)
>
> On another note: I will be continuing the other one people have been loving that started as short under "Fan requests" sometime soon, although I think I'll be just moving that to its own series so that "Fan requests" can stay as a bunch of shorts. So don't panic if you see it disappear from Fan Requests. I'll make that into its own thing under that name.

DON'T HATE ME

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

AH. I don't mean to be a tease! I just know it's been five-ever since I've updated this story and I wanted everyone -especially those who have been patiently waiting, who have been with me since the start of this crazy series -to know that I FINALLY started writing the next bit. I will be posting a new chapter soon <3 It is NOT the final chapter, have no fear. It's not going to be anything fantastic or amazing -the wheels have just started turning again.

Chapter End Notes

Hope everyone is safe and well for the Holidays -however and whatever you celebrate.

On another note: can we all just agree that the concept of needing money sometimes just...sucks??

Preparing for Battle

Chapter Summary

Surprise! DT backed out and disappeared.

Chapter Notes

Short but sweet! Just getting back into the swing of things :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra knew she shouldn't have been surprised. After all, life did seem to have this funny way of always -ALWAYS- finding a way to fuck her over.

Had she known the person Adora was suddenly relying on was Double Trouble, she could have at least warned her that this would happen. That little snake cared about one thing, and one thing only: themself. Of course they would promise an answer, the end to it all, and then disappear without a trace. Of course.

She remembered very clearly the one and only time she ever met them.

It was a simple side job: walk into the room, give the guy a brick, and walk out. But no, fate wasn't so kind as to give her such a casual interaction. She walks in and finds a broken-looking man slouching in the chair, sullen eyes and frown lines so set in his skin they seemed like they'd remain even if he smiled.

She did her part. She offered the package, told him to take it. Slowly, unseeing eyes find it and go wide. He starts crying and refuses -says he can't do this anymore, he can't TAKE it anymore. The man -who was clearly coming down from something -asked the four uncaring walls what he should do."M-my family!" but he got no answer. Catra didn't understand and she couldn't deal with the way this had all started to make her skin crawl. She was thankful when the man walked -no, ran- out, mumbling something

about needing to just get away. Catra stood staring at the floor for a moment, wondering what she'd gotten herself into, when they walked in.

"Bad luck, there, kitten." She looked to the voice in the doorway, the owner of which gave life and a third dimension to the words 'laissez faire'. They approached with swagger, totally unphased by the man's very obvious distress."Ah well. You did what was asked of you." Something about their expression -the eyes maybe- was, not quite predatory, per se, but rather...opportunistic. Vulture. This person was a vulture.

They handed eight hundred dollar bills. Catra didn't understand.

"Rob said four hundred."

They shrugged with a sly smile. "Consider it hazard pay, darling."

"What the hell's that supposed to mean?" Only later that night would she really think about the encounter and consider the potential dangers of dealing with unhinged drug addicts.

"Ah, to be young and naive." The feeling of something crawling under her skin had only intensified. "You don't belong in this business sweetheart. Stick to dancing." Catra wanted to tell them to fuck off. If she wanted to earn a little extra on the side for weird shit like this, she could. Right? Right. But she took too long. Hordak's little weasel was already on the way out. "Keep the coke. He won't be needing it anymore." The words chilled the room with the dawning of their truth. People always say dealing is a one-way road with no turn-offs.

His fate was sealed then.

She shuddered, now alone in the dimly lit room. No. They were right. Whether or not she could handle this side of the business wasn't relevant. She didn't WANT to be involved -not like this. Whatever it was that was happening, she didn't want to know - not their names, not their faces, not their sullen eyes, like her mother's. She wanted no part in profiting off the world preying on

people's feeblemindedness, off their greed and willingness to fuck each other over for the next high, the next paycheck, the next not-my-problem situation -for really anything. .

She marched right up to Rob, shoved the package against his chest, hard, and said, "Don't you ever, and I mean, NEVER, ask me to do that shit again. You got it? I don't care how much you pay me."

And he never did.

"Catra?"

She was pulled from the haunting memory -one of many she'd previously tucked away and written off as an oddity, without really considering what it meant. "Do you know them?"

She blinked a few times, re-setting her eyes to the pleasant holiday table cloth in front of her -a stark contrast to where her mind had just been. "No. We met once, but...that was it."

Adora's whole body seemed to relax. "Do you know anything about them?"

"They work closely with Hordak, but that's all I know."

"...Christ…" Annnd back to tense again. "That's what I was afraid of."

"But you still have the phone records, the emails." Catra wasn't exactly sure what that expression on Adora's face was, but she knew it wasn't good.

"Those things are all considered to be fairly subjective without a witness testimony corroborating them." Uh oh...a pit formed in her stomach and threatened briefly to relieve her of the lunch they'd just shared.

"Why? They're more real than people -especially people like that who just lie to save their own skin."

The blonde pinched the bridge of her nose and then let her hand fall back to the table. "Only in the most straightforward of instances." Catra could already feel what was coming, wanting desperately to just go hole up in their bed as a response to the inevitable. "Nothing in what we've got outright shows Hordak taking part in procuring prostitutes. In all his correspondents, he just talks about meeting up with people or hosting events, which, by name could be totally innocent. And all of that is subject to interpretation by people in the jury." Catra set her chin down on her folded arms. Great. "He's got some of the best lawyers in the state in his pocket, and they're sure to try and appeal to his character."

"HA!" The laugh that tore from her throat was bitter. She may have actually barfed a little. "What Character?"

"Zachary Prime isn't exactly a public figure, but he's pretty damn close and he's got a good name. He donated millions to charities all over last year, his contributions to the natural science museum practically funded their deep-sea expedition last year, and I'm fairly certain he also backed the northern bridge reconstruction with an express lane up North. A jury is going to look at those texts and emails and say, 'now here is a philanthropist who does a lot for other people behind the scenes'. He's been really smart about it until recently, but even so, what we need is somebody to connect the subjective dots found in all that stuff, somebody to tell a personal story about all his shady shit. Catra…"

"No." But she'd already lost. If that's what was needed and she was the only one who could do it, she didn't have a choice."

"Catra, this case needs you to testify against Hordak."

She put her forehead down and stared at her feet. "Fuck."

"We can't get ahold of anyone else with a strong enough testimony. He assaulted you in your place of work, he threatened you and your boss, and you can attest to the fact that he was

attempting to buy you the same way he had bought other women. You got to see that side of things at the club."

"Thanks for the reminder."

"I'm sorry…" Catra felt a twinge of guilt. "I just...I want to see him put away for good. I want to know that he can't hurt anyone ever again." The 'especially you' was implied.

Catra sighed and raised her head, unable to meet Adora's pleading gaze. Some part of her just needed to be combative, even though she'd already given in. "He can still kill people from prison, you know."

"Not half as easily."

They wait in silence for a time before Adora starts to clear the dishes from the table. "I understand what it's asking of you, and I know-"

"I'll do it."

"-that it's scary, but if we-"

She repeats herself, louder this time. "I'll testify."

Adora's movements stop and she sets the plates down gently. She turns to face the brunette looking almost surprised. Glad to know you have so much faith in me, geez. "You will?"

Catra shrugs as if the notion doesn't freak her the fuck out -sitting in front of a bunch of people, on a literal stand, recounting the story of how she was viewed by society as a play toy for years. Awesome. "The world needs to know he's a scummy piece of shit."

Adora just nods, thoughtfully. The determination set in her jaw suggests she's thinking of all the ways it may go wrong - something Catra always found particularly comforting in a quirky sort of way. It meant Adora was trying to find ways to keep them

safe amidst the chaos to come. “We’ll be okay.” Hazel and green eyes met steely blue for the first time since the conversation started. “You’ll be okay, Catra. We’re going to end this, together.”

And Catra believed her.

Chapter End Notes

Hereeeee we go!

Stuck in a Story

Chapter Summary

> A little insight into how these two are feeling leading up to the trial.

Chapter Notes

> *insert shrug* It's a crawl to the finish line, but it's worth it. Thanks for hanging in here with me gang!

Adora dons a black suit for the occasion. It’s plain, but it makes her feel secure somehow, sturdy -almost as if she’s willing herself to manifest the lawful order she hopes will come from the trial. She needs to feel that way today- for Catra’s sake and for her own -that the peoples of the court would do right, that SHE had done right.

As if existential dread in the normative realm wasn’t enough, she’s been paranoid for the last three weeks, just waiting for somebody to pop out from behind a bush and off the woman she loves more than anything. She’s paranoid that she’ll be helpless. Catra tries to tease her about it but Adora knows it’s only to mask her own fear.

Catra tells her that she looks like she’s getting ready for a funeral with a forced half-smirk, but Adora can tell she’s nervous. She’s taken extra time with her makeup, making deliberate strokes and thin lines that make her look like she’s trying to be as average as possible -because she just needed something to focus on -one step at a time. That’s how they were going to get through this. Adora watches her shoes -kitten heels -as she walks down the steps slowly. Left, right, left, right. She must be thinking about each step too. When the car door shuts, they both breathe.

“Are you ready?”

“As I’ll ever be.”

The car ride there is silent except for the deafening combination of road noise and worry. Adora knows they have a strong case - strengthened by the fact that otherwise witnesses to Hordak's heinous activities were murdered, and there was not one, but TWO failed attempts to take or kill Catra, the only other remaining witness. Still, there was some part of her that feared the outcome of this trial. Hordak had deep pockets. He could have paid off the jury. He could have some rando there to finish the job. Not to mention he hired the infamous "Imp" for his defense. Adora had no doubt whatsoever that they would try to delegitimize Catra's testimony at every turn.

But they had to win. They had to.

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She was trapped. From the moment she agreed to testify, she was caged. So many meetings with lawyers and with the police and now...now this -the real deal. This is what it was all for.

They pull up to the courthouse and Catra thinks she's never seen it like this. Sure, she's driven passed now and then, and yeah, it's big. But now, at the base of the brick-laden steps that seem to go a mile high, she's unable to move of her own accord. The shadow this building casts in the morning sun haunts her; it watches her like every other person in the crowd gathered there with their microphones and cameras and questions. She's thankful that she's inside of this bubble of officers -which is meant to protect her from any more attempts to kill her -but it's also one of the things making her feel so stuck.

Stuck in this mass of people. Stuck in her head. Stuck in this awful story that she's had to rehearse and rehearse and fucking rehearse. The worst part was, it's HER story. No, it's her life, but she's had to explain it so many times now it feels more like the plot of a book than her own memories. And after today, when it does get put down into dictated words -stripped of human embodied experience and translated into legal mumbo-jumbo

bullshit for some asshate law-school kid to read ten years from now -she'll be forever stuck as the victim of this story told.

Somehow they've cleared the steps and she can't even hear her own goddamn thoughts over the sound of this crowd talking and asking and walking and snapping. The click-clack of her own shoes against this gorgeous marble flooring is lost as they make their way down a huge hall with cream-colored pillars and bright lights that show a patterned ceiling -as if anyone who came to this place had the time or mental energy to sit and stare at a goddamn ceiling. They walk down a long hallway and as they enter two large, wooden doors, Catra seems to forget everything she was told.

Suddenly, things became very, very real.

Okay. We're really doing this.

Take Me Home

Chapter Summary

> Nearing the end fam. Here's the trial and a surprise plot throwback.

Chapter Notes

> Y'all. Thank you for sticking with me through all this, and the long, LOOOOOOOOONG freaking break. I'm back and ready to finish this monster.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The judge was an esteemed man considered to be fair, which was lucky. Adora's certain that the frown lines on his face are deep enough that they remain even when he smiles, which is to be expected when, regardless of what you do, somebody hates you for it. Only somebody who cares enough to follow their own moral compass would have such lines, because only somebody who cares would be willing to be hated for it. So Adora wasn't worried about the judge nearly as much as she was about the jury. Any number of them could be paid off. If Hordak's calmness is anything to go by, she would bet money that most of them were, because she knew they had a strong case. His whole life was being flushed down the drain but he seemed completely unphased. She just hoped she was wrong.

They have substantive proof that he frequented the club and met with the owner, directly, for 'business'. They have a strong argument for Huntara working for him and along with that, evidence which resulted in a conviction suggesting he hired her to murder people to cover up the operation, which in turn further connected them both to lower drug lords. They had suspicious security footage, bank statements, business registers, text messages, emails, etc —some of the latter thanks to Entrapta. And, of course, she and Catra's testimonies would tie all of the

pieces together into a gut-wrenching story of corruption and greed and all-around inhumanity.

The room itself was full of stuffy air and stiff bodies, just waiting, but it felt oddly quiet except for a buzz of tension, almost like a mosquito right by your ear. Adora's hands itched to swat at something untouchable, to brush it away and just focus, but there's nothing physically there. None of it was real. Not the irritating non-sound rattling her thoughts, not the imaginary shadow crawling under her skin and causing her to shift uncomfortably in her seat, and certainly not the vivid image that kept replaying in her head of Zackary Prime standing and walking away a free man. That absolutely would not become real. She's done everything she could for the last few months, practically every waking moment she could spare —much to Catra and Glimmer and Bow's dismay— making sure that won't be the outcome. Still, the gagged and bound pessimistic voice in some dusty corner of her mind tried to scream that she doesn't control everything —she can't. What if she can't fix this?

She glanced at Catra who looked absolutely stunning despite being utterly exhausted. She always was good at that, masking any and all unwanted feelings behind a shield of confidence. She'd broken down more times than Adora cared to count in the weeks prior, and she often went back and forth between shutting down and being quite needy, which was nothing new; the swings were just exacerbated by all of the heightened emotions. Fear. Anger. Grief. So much grief. And yet, here she was, so brave. SO brave. Her angular features and cool presentation made her look fierce amidst all of this bullshit.

Catra was a fighter, but this fight wasn't like any other she'd been in before. This fight was about the kind of power that requires no skill; this fight was about social power and money and bureaucratic red tape and imaginary lines drawn in the sand. But they were going to win.

In the last few weeks, they'd rehearsed for this fight over and over and over again with their lawyer. Catra needed to be very

vulnerable in a room full of strangers —something that inherently goes against her nature. She hated being a victim more than anything. But no matter how many times her eyes scanned the room, no matter how many times she forced herself to look forward, her gaze seemed to be drawn back to Zachary Prime. He was a cold-looking behemoth of a man —a gorilla in a suit with glassy eyes and leathery skin from too much time on a private island. Each time her eyes settled on him, his indignant expression, the carefree way he sat, the fit of his no doubt custom-tailored coat, Adora's blood boiled so hot it may as well have been vapor in the air. She willed it to poison him, to make its way into his lungs and fill them up until there was no room for air, causing him to choke on the very same kind of malice he dealt so casually.

The Bright Moon City prosecutor stood to give the opening statement to the court. His voice was light, with an almost airy quality to it, something rather jarring for somebody in his line of work. "Ladies and gentlemen of the jury, this city has known its fair share of criminals. But I dare say that few have committed crimes so heinous as those examined today. The evidence we have brought to you this day proves beyond the shadow of a doubt that this man-" Many eyes follow his hand, shifting to Prime who remains unmoved. "—who parades about our city under the facade of a so-called philanthropist…"

The bastard had the gaul to smirk at that. Adora's knuckles started to turn white from how hard she gripped the side of the seat.
"—has been the head of operations that I should hope any good-natured, upstanding citizen would consider to be a crime against humanity…"

And so it begins.
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Catra cried silently throughout the entirety of Adora's questioning and all the parts about her traitorous partner killing Stace and Rob at the club. At some point she was able to sort of turn off and shut down. By the time she came into her body again, she was already being moved towards the witness stand on shaking legs. She was sworn in and, for a moment, panic gripped her. There was only one circumstance in which she enjoyed being the center of attention and this couldn't be further from it.

Hordak's lawyer was a short, fat man who looked a lot like a bat —a sharply upturned nose that was too big for his stout little face, and eyes that seemed to bulge just a bit behind his thick, goggle glasses. But the suit he wore was crisp and designer, like what anyone near Hordak would wear. Not enough money in the world could fix your kind of ugly, sweetheart.

His questions didn't exactly throw her for a loop. They had been prepared for the defense to try and smear her character. Did she use recreational drugs? Yes. Did she abuse alcohol and certain narcotics? Yes. Did she go to work under the influence? Yes. Like every other fucking person on the planet at some point in their lives. Was she under the influence on the day Hordak visited? No. Was she sure? Yes. And it continued on that way —they asked pointless questions for what felt like an eternity, attempting to paint her as some desperate and detached-from-reality addict whose story couldn't be trusted.

And then their lawyer came up for the cross-examination. This was the hard part. This was where he very kindly asked her to spill her guts about being a damsel in distress, treated like chattel, almost taken into actual slavery. Fuck.

She's asked to take a breath and she does. She's asked to tell about how Rob runs "the human " side of business through Hordak, and she does. The defense objects because of a lack of substantial proof. The judge tells them to continue. She's asked to recount the day Hordak came to visit, and she does. The defense motions for dismissal because they don't have "proof" that Catra was assaulted. It's denied. She's asked to recount the evening

Adora came to save her, and she does. The defense interjects again that they don't know Hordak's directly connected to the men who came to take her. Again, they're denied.

One breath at a time, Catra got through it. That's the only reason she was here in the first place. Her whole fucking life was just days full of breathing in and out and trying to get through. For what, she didn't know most of the time. She just had to breathe. So today, fueled by oxygen and rage, she told her story —to get to whatever that next thing was.

To her surprise, she didn't even take notice of the people in the jury or in the stands behind the first row of seats in the room. They all just sort of blurred together to make a boring, abstract suit-color wheel of stillness. The whole time words were forced from her body, she watched Hordak —through her tears, through her anger, through her shame and grief—she watched him. Each time they were denied, he looked smaller and smaller to her, until she saw nothing but a snivelling toddler in an expensive suit. Pathetic.

She's pulled from the stand at some point and Adora goes back up in her place, and it made sense. It would always make sense. Adora was always that next thing. It was never about just getting through to the next day, or even the day after. It was about getting BACK to Adora, to feeling alive again, to feeling whole. She let herself be lulled into a peaceful state of existence by her voice. Even as tense as it was now, it was still a comfort to Catra's body and soul, much like her heartbeat. When this was all over, she was going to collapse on top of her and fall asleep to that sound.

She was pulled from her stupor when the closing arguments began, which really seemed like a waste of time. The evidence against Hordak was damning to say the least, and the defense's attempts to debunk it had failed majorly. The only thing they could provide in his defense was really that he donated a lot of money to charity and shook a lot of hands —a pretty trash argument if you asked Catra. But they were still sweating. Catra

had overheard Adora telling somebody over the phone she was worried that the jury had been paid off. If that was the case, so help her God, she would kill him herself.

Needless to say, when they heard the word "Guilty on all accounts", they all let out a collective gust of air. The room seemed to burst with movement and noise behind them, like everyone else had thought the same thing about the jury. Catra hadn't meant to, but she laughed. It was a quick, singular "ha" of surprise before she was able to stifle it. Adora gave her a look, but she was too distracted by the vein making an appearance on Hordak's forehead —the only indication of upset on his stone face as the judge read ALL of his charges.

"For repeat accounts of solicitation, pimping, and pandering, money laundering and federal tax evasion, international and national drug trafficking, as well as trafficking in persons, assault and battery, and at least two counts of solicitation of murder for hire, the jury finds the defendant guilty." He removed his glasses and peered down at Hordak for a moment. "For his crimes, the defendant is hereby sentenced to life in prison without parole, given his, not one, but three life-sentences."

The gavel struck wood and with a loud CRACK, it was done. They'd won.

As they all stood to be dismissed, Catra turned again to watch him. Now a vein in his neck stood out and the only other sign that he was about to pop was the way one corner of his mouth twitched. Catra was so overflowing with relief that she felt almost giddy. They were dismissed and noise erupted all around them. She smiled at him, which made the lip twitch more exaggerated, his eyes slightly wider as he took her in. Two officers made their way towards him, and she barely withheld another bout of laughter. She re-imagined their meeting that day. This time, she

stood over him. This time, she fought back. '...she has a pretty mouth…". She couldn't help herself.

She was already riding a high, adrenaline coursing through her. "Hey Hordak." Many pairs of eyes turned to her as her hand raised to pump an invisible dick by her mouth. "Put that mouth to good use in prison."

The ugly redness of his face was almost instantaneous. She won. She made him crack, the rat-bastard. It was only when she saw his cane in his still-free hand did her smugness melt away. Sure enough, his cuffed hand wrenched away from the officer and pulled the tiny pistol from its head, no doubt loaded with bullets intended as retribution. So many things happened at once. Somewhere behind her she heard Adora's gasped "Catra", along with other people's indiscriminate gasps. Catra saw the officers launching at him, grabbing him, but she still heard the CRACK through the air, felt its sound. It was so much louder than that of the gavel, and so much more final. Somebody screamed as she blinked once, watching smoke rise from a tiny gun now clattering to the floor as its user quickly followed.

As quickly as fear came, it was gone again. Arms wrapped around her body and wrenched her away —Adora's body shielding her. She wheeled her head around to see now four officers taking Hordak to the ground in front of the pews with an anguished, animalistic growl. His head was now all the same purply-red color as he squirmed under other large bodies. Cameras were flashing and people were yelling. Adora was patting her down and trying to make sure that the bullet hadn't struck her. The officers had bat his arm away just quick enough.

Catra laughed. She laughed so hard she cried and then continued laughing. She laughed through Adora telling her how stupid that was and how could she do that? Eventually Adora just gave in and let her laugh, smiling back at her with the worry-crinkle in her forehead. Catra laughed until they were outside in the fresh air and Catra didn't have to force her breath anymore. It was over. It was really, really over.

When she finally spoke, she very definitively said. “Adora, take me home.”

Chapter End Notes

This isn't exactly the end, but we're real close.

If you like it then you'd better "_____"

Chapter Summary

Adora finally puts a ring on it. They're doin' it y'all. It's official.

Chapter Notes

I'm not crying, you're crying!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Every now and then, she had nightmares about that day two years ago, about Zackary Prime pulling that single-shot nine millimeter pistol and aiming squarely at Catra's unprotected body; about not getting there fast enough and watching her world crumple on the floor as chaos erupts in that courtroom around them. When she wakes up to Catra holding her sweaty body, unharmed and sleeping undisturbed, like a log, she calms down. They were safe now. She was safe now.

It took some months for things to settle down after the success of the trial, and another few just to get used to the quietness of the aftermath. Catra took time off work—which, thankfully, she could afford to do—to figure out what her next pursuit would be. Adora would never get tired of how her mind worked, how she always sought to create something, to infuse things with the same flair of her personality. The project she set her heart on was no exception.

When the jewelry Stace left to Catra was finally released from police custody as evidence in the case, Stace's husband, Trevor, tried to reclaim all of her assets. They were able to get a good personal lawyer who made a strong case in Catra's favor. All of the contents of that safety deposit box was given to her. Trevor was so angered that he followed them into the parking lot, berating them. Just as Adora was about to turn and knock his lights out,

Catra dealt several blows that laid him low herself. He seemed genuinely afraid as she gave him what Adora thought must have been a speech she rehearsed a million times. They never heard from him again.

Catra used the money from selling most of the jewelry to buy an old abandoned convenience store from the county in one of the oldest parts of town near where she'd grown up. They spent fourteen grueling months completely gutting the building, renovating, and re-designing it. Before, it was a sad and dilapidated shoe-box of a place, with chipped paint that had been graffitied over too many times and dark, boarded windows. Now it possessed life. The outside featured mural work from some well-liked street artists Catra was able to track down; it was full of vibrant colors, young faces representing different backgrounds, and a cityscape view. People often took photos in front of it.

Walking in from the street was the bar, stocked with any and all manner of hard liquor. On the walls hung photos of dancers and classic Hollywood stars, performers—beautiful people. Towards the back there was a stage where they would host burlesque shows every Wednesday, open mic nights on Thursday, local DJ's on Fridays, comedians on Saturdays, and jazz on Sunday. Through double doors was the dance studio, walled with ceiling-to-floor mirrors. During the day Catra held classes or private dance lessons, and at 11:00pm, it doubled as a dance floor for the bar. Outside hung a neon sign that said "Stace's Place" from noon to two in the morning.

It was a raging success—one of the first buildings to be praised for 'bringing young people back' to this part of the city, and for renewing nightlife. It was the most popular club in a 10 mile radius, and it brought Catra more joy than anything Adora could have imagined. The classes she taught were so full that some people had to practice just outside the doors on summer days. So many of them were kids, ten to sixteen year-olds from neighborhoods where Catra grew up. You could see in their eyes, the way they lit up, how confidently they moved, that this gave

them freedom in a way that nothing else could, the same way it did for her all those years ago.

It brought Adora to tears sometimes to see them with her, the way they looked up to her, the way she counselled them, touched their lives. It felt like some of them were almost close enough to be their own children; sometimes they would come and stay with Adora and Catra when they needed to get out of their house. Or sometimes Catra would pack them lunches to take to school if she felt they didn't have any. Adora occasionally acted as a 'tutor' for some of them with homework. This was their home.

Even though Adora still had next to no rhythm—something ALL of Catra's students now knew—she still very much enjoyed being at the studio, watching. This day was only different because of her nerves. She was quieter and did less cheering, just admiring off to the side imagining the rest of the night over, and over again. She found herself distracted easily, worrying about small things like a stray dust bunny in the corner to avoid the unthinkable question: 'what if she says no?'. She won't. Adora knows she won't, partially because Catra's been dropping hints for months, which apparently weren't so much hints as they were outright conversations involving any and all words other than "I'm" and "ready".

The weight of the ring in her pocket was light —far, far too light— considering how expensive it was. She'd thought about how to do this exactly 215 times, and now she just had to ask the question. It took months to feel like the ring was right, even though it had a simple enough design—Catra liked the finer things to be simple. So the band was plain white gold, topped with a row of marquise and round-cut moissanite stones. She knew Catra didn't much care for diamonds on principle, even though she admired the sparkle. When the jeweler had first given it to Adora after it was finished, she took it back to her car and stared for what must have been a whole half hour. God, it was so sparkly.

Then the anxiety kicked in. What if she dropped it? What if it falls out when she's moving around and she loses it? What if she gives it away too soon? She had a plan, and she had every intention of

sticking to it, but all of the articles and blogs she read made it clear to 'go with the flow' —something she inherently had issues with. She needed this to be perfect for Catra, the woman of her dreams who sometimes still didn't feel real, who managed to save Adora from herself more times than she could count, who could have the world at her feet with a single playful smile.

They should have a proposal that was fitting for them as a couple, so tonight Adora was going to give Catra a dose of her own medicine. She would goad her into asking for what she really wanted. She would FINALLY have to say, out loud, that she wanted to get married.

The blonde watched as her girlfriend paced back and forth in front of the room, practically yelling over the music and the hollers. Her shirt was darkened with sweat, clinging to a lithe, fit body underneath. With everyone dancing, spread out about the studio, it looked a bit like chaos —some of the younger kids off-beat and less confident. Catra always did well in chaos. She moved through it like water, naturally. "Again! This is the last time for today, we're gonna do it all together, yeah? Take a minute before we go back to the top."

Their eyes meet and Catra smiles and mouths 'almost done'. Adora has to resist the urge to grip the ring in her pocket again. Almost time.

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Catra was ready to ring her neck by dessert, which was absolutely lovely, but still. Here she was, in a dress that could wake the dead, sitting across the table from the love of her life, just WAITING for Adora to pop the question —which she'd been doing for actual MONTHS. She'd dropped so many hints and they'd had so many conversations about it, about having kids and finding 'their dream home'. It had to be tonight, all the cues were there!

Adora said it was going to be a ‘special night’, and they got reservations at this boujee-ass steakhouse, their own private table on the balcony with a decent view of the city. Adora ordered the food for Catra, which she’s never done in their whole entire lives together, and gets her this oddly specific Shiraz-Grenache blend that she seemed weirdly excited about. Since when did Adora give a shit about wines? And she was being uncomfortably cryptic with the waiter, which was weird. So Catra’s thinking the ring’s in the wine, right? Like at the bottom of the glass. Catra has said, verbatim, that she wouldn’t hate a proposal like that.

So she was all excited, heart pounding outside of her chest for twenty minutes while Adora watched her eat like a hawk. But no. She was so careful as she got down to the bottom of her glass, only to find that it was ringless. Then Adora took her hand and started getting all mushy, talking about how much she loved her, all the feelings, and then she got down on one knee... TO TIE HER SHOE. To tie her fucking shoe. The brunette couldn’t help but laugh, despite the inner let-down. Only Adora, with her big, loving, innocent eyes, could be so clueless and confused in that moment as to what was going through Catra’s mind. Her eyebrow furrowed with concern and Catra had to just smile and say ‘I’ll tell you later’.

They sat and talked and laughed in the romantic candlelit ambiance for almost a full hour after finishing their meal. Between work, spending more time with a couple kids from the studio, and running the bar, she’d been feeling like they hadn’t had enough quality alone time lately. Regardless of what happened tonight, just being out with Adora like this and being able to give each other full attention was really, really nice. She looked forward to the end of summer when things would quiet down just a little bit. Plus they were hiring a manager to officially run Stace’s, and that would take a huge load off Catra's plate. Then maybe they could have more nights like this one.

When they got back to the car, they drove in silence with the windows down. The air was crisp and the sky was clear tonight. Catra caught herself almost humming contentedly along to the

sound of the engine as they went. When Adora missed their usual turn, she asked "Where are we going?"

Adora's fingers gently squeezed her thigh through the dress. "You'll see."

As Catra looked out the window, she watched the trees along the road swallow the dark sky the further they got. With each winding turn of the pavement, she became more certain of where they were headed. The trees became thinner towards the top of the hill and the cityscape skyline came into view, all different colors of lights reflecting off high-rise windows. Catra smiled as they pulled off the road at their lookout spot. They hadn't been back here in almost a year. The blackberry bushes seemed overgrown, but that also meant more privacy—something they would have given anything for as teenagers.

Catra glanced over at the blonde as she turned the car off and knew without a doubt that Adora was, in fact, going to propose tonight. Adora's smiling face was utterly transparent, but surely she knew that because she wasn't trying to mask it either, which was refreshing. Catra smiled back, ordering the emotion she read reflecting back at her.

1. 'I love you so much'
2. Content
3. Excited
4. Nervous

Adora gave a slight nod. "Let's get out."

Catra got herself unbuckled and checked that the top of the dress still looked good before opening the door to find Adora standing there holding a blanket for them to sit on, looking quite eager. "A blanket? Careful Adora. A girl might think you're just looking for a hookup." Even now, after years of teasing, such a comment still brought a light dusting of pink to those perfect cheeks.

“That dress is beautiful, I don’t want it to get dirty.” Always the gentleman. Some things never change.

Catra smiled. “You’ve only said that ten times tonight.” She takes Adora’s hand and walks —carefully, in her heels—to the clearing. “If you think you like the dress, you should see what’s underneath.”

“Oh, I plan to.”

They stepped over a particularly muddy spot on the ground and Catra inhaled the familiar scent of wet earth after a good rain. Of course Adora would bring a blanket. “Wow, so confident.” Now they stood in front of the most beautiful view of the city, their view, and all Catra could look at was Adora.

“You know you can’t resist me.” The blonde wiggled her eyebrows. Doofus.

Catra brought her hands to either side of Adora’s face and smiled up at her, giving a fake, long sigh. “You’re right. For whatever reason I can’t say no. And I’d say at least take me to dinner first, but you already did that...so…” She swam in Adora’s eyes for a moment, coming back only to breathe again. “I’m all yours, Adora.” There’s no harm in a little set-up if Adora was nervous about the proposal.

Catra let her hands fall to Adora’s neck to pull herself in, who seemed just as eager for the kiss. It never got old. She got to do this every day and she would never grow tired of kissing this woman, feeling those hands roam around her waist and hold her close. But Adora was the one to break away this time, somewhat awkwardly clearing her throat, looking even more nervous somehow.“Uh, blanket.” The word was halfway between a statement and a question. Catra’s heart began to beat a little bit quicker again, so sure that this was it. She was so ready. SO ready for this. Adora could give her a twig, or a wet blade of grass and she’d be overjoyed. Hell, she was overjoyed just thinking about saying the word “yes”.

Feeling giddy and wanting nothing more than to crawl into Adora's lap and kiss her again, she lowered herself onto the blanket. "Catra…" Adora sounded unsteady. "I have a question, and I really want you to think about it before you answer." Ba-dup. Catra held her breath and she bit her tongue to stop from yelling the word that's been bouncing around in her head all night. Adora took a deep, slow breath in, and she couldn't fight the smile from spreading across her face. This is it.

"When we paint the bathroom, what color do you want the accent wall to be?"

Several moments went by where they just stared at each other before Catra determined that she'd heard correctly. Her heart dropped, but she laughed.

"THAT is your big important question that you had to ask right now?"

Adora seemed confused."Yeah?"

"You brought me out here to talk about the house renovations?"

She shrugged defensively. "No, but I was thinking about it and I needed to know. I'm worried you won't like the same color as me.'

"Hmm. "As she turned to look out at the city, Catra's feelings were somewhere between frustration and bemusement, but she couldn't tell which was winning out. Frustration, for sure. Or, rather, worry. What if she read all of this wrong? What if Adora wasn't actually ready yet? She's been sounding ready.

"Why, what did you think I was going to ask you?"

"HA! C'mon Adora, even you're not THAT oblivious.."

She gave a small shrug, her face looking apologetic. "Well, maybe I am. So spell it out for me."

Catra sighs, feeling a tiny bit guilty, like she's ruining what might otherwise be a completely normal conversation. Catra feels bad for misinterpreting what has apparently just been Adora's totally innocent date-night intentions, full of more unconditional love thank Catra deserves, spoiling her in the way that she lives for. "We get all dressed up to go out for a really nice dinner where you were being kind of weird. And you're all lovey with me and we talk about having babies and then we come out here, somewhere that's really sentimental to us both and our relationship, and it's beautiful out and you brought a blanket...and then you tell me you have 'an important question'."

"Okay?…" Adora really doesn't get it…Catra raises her eyebrows.

"Adora, look at this!" She gestures to the view. "Look at us!"

"Catra, I don't know if you noticed, but I've BEEN looking at you. All night." God, Catra wants to shake her and ride her stupid, beautiful face. So hot. So, so hot, but so dumb. And all hers.

"EXACTLY!"

"So? I've been looking at you practically every day since I was ten. And I intend to continue that trend for the rest of our lives."

UGH! "That! Right there. See? How does that NOT scream, 'Marry me'?"

Adora rocks back. "OHhhhhh. You thought I was going to ask you to marry me?" Catra covers her face with her hands for just a moment.

"How could I not?"

"Do you want me to ask you to marry me?" She looks up to find Adora's attempt to stifle herself —the corner of her mouth just barely curled, which almost immediately spreads into an infectious smile.

“Of COURSE I do.” As soon as she says the words, she recognizes the mischievous smugness in that lovable face. Catra understood —Adora had planned all of this. She continued on anyways, eyes stinging a bit, heart back up in her chest again, beating wildly. “What I want most in this world is for you to ask me to marry you, to be your wife.”

Adora shrugs. “Okay.” And smiles like she’s won the lottery.

Catra pounces on her lap, not caring if she ruins her dress, a single tear already spilling out. “You’re such an idiot.”

“Yes but I’m your idiot, and I’m glad we’re officially on the same page...” The blonde shifts underneath her as she reaches to pull a small black box out of her pocket. “Because you know how I am with gifts.” It was true. Adora was a compulsory gift giver. She couldn’t hold onto a present to save her life. One year, Catra received six Christmas presents between August and November. “So keeping this from you has killed me every day for the last two mo-”

Catra kissed her to stop her wonderful rambling, and to prevent a happy sob from tearing from her own throat. Arms around her neck, she kissed her, and laughed, and whispered a choked ‘yes’ against Adora’s lips. Well, her teeth really —she was smiling too hard for there to be much lip involved. “Catra—” She tried to talk between the kisses and shared tears of joy. “Catra, wait —at least, let me— ask.”

“Yes—” She couldn’t stop. If she stopped kissing Adora she was just going to cry.

“Catraaaa.”

Breathlessly, she pulled away to rest their heads together. They both sniffled and after a moment Catra opened her eyes to find Adora’s sparkling back at her, pleadingly. She checked herself—she did just make a big stink about Adora not properly asking. “Sorry. I’m sorry.” Adora gave a nod and cleared her throat. “Go ahead.”

Catra pulled herself a respectable distance away to just straddle Adora's lap so she could see her face, now wet but so, so happy.

"Catra," The brunette heard her try to swallow the lump in her throat. "I love you more than anything in the world," She drew in a heavy breath. "...through the good days and the hard days. And, I say hard because the only bad days are the ones I've had to spend without you." Catra bites her lip again to keep from exploding. "And I always want you by my side. You make me a better person and I want to spend every day showing that to you." GOD, Adora please just ask me!

"So...I'm asking you now to officially take your rightful place in our family as my partner. Will you marry me, Catra?"

She pounces again, drawing an 'oof' and a gust of air from Adora. "YES. Yes! Yes, I will."

"Catra! You didn't even look at the ring!"

She pulls back, shaking her head. The tears keep coming just as fast as she wipes them. God she's bad at this. "Sorry! I know. I'm just—" She sees it. "Oh my god."

The unsuspecting little black box is holding a ring sparkling an abnormal amount considering it's lit only by the light of the moon and the city. She looks back at Adora, who now appears unsure, just waiting for a response. She looks back and forth between her fucking FIANCE and the one ring to rule them all. "Adora, oh my god —it's beautiful!" The design was simple, but bold and unique.

Adora cracked another huge smile. "Do you wanna try it on, or—" "Yes! Of course I do."

She manages to force herself to sit back again —admittedly a bit less comfortably than the first time—as Adora all too carefully pulls the ring from its box and slips it over her finger. It's a perfect fit.

This time when she tackles Adora, she lets herself be taken down to the blanket and Catra finally gets to just enjoy kissing her. "I love you."

"I love you so much."

Catra squeezes her fingers together over the ring to test how it feels. It's significantly more comfortable than she would have guessed. She's so full of raw emotion she could burst. Despite the cold air on her back, she feels like she's melting into Adora beneath her. As lips move toward the hollow below her jaw, she wonders how fast Adora can get her out of this dress. Then, suddenly, the hands around her waist seize and the blonde stiffens.

"Bwah—wait! The photographer!"

Catra pulls back. "The what?"

Adora's eyes are huge and she looks scandalized. "I may or may not have hired a photographer to capture, uh, 'the moment'"

Catra cocks and eyebrow and moves her hips in a circle. "What, you don't wanna give them a show?"

Adora flushes in the moonlight and she's easily the most beautiful thing Catra's ever seen—still. Always. "Catraaa. We want family friendly engagement photos that we can show to people!"

She rolls her eyes. "Okay, okay. Fine. But the second we get home, the clothes are coming OFF."

"Deal. They should be coming over here soon to take some more photos, so we should probably...you know...get up."

As they stand, an explosion makes both of them jump back. No, not one, many —almost simultaneous pops and cracks and sizzles light up the sky in front of them. " He told me he couldn't get the permit for the fireworks!"

Catra held onto Adora as she laughed. “You got Seahawk to light fireworks for us?”

She didn’t need Adora to answer. She could tell by the way they looked utterly uncontrolled that the answer was yes. They were beautiful anyways. So they held each other and kissed under the stars and the wild patterns of colors flashing in the sky that almost matched the ones Catra felt.

And the photos turned out perfect, and everyone loved them.

Chapter End Notes

I just wanna say a big, fat THANK YOU to everyone who's been with me from the start of this crazy journey. This whole long series started with what was meant to be a one-shot. And now we're here.

I marked this as the end, but I may come back and add a years-later chapter featuring life with Finn. I may also come back at some point and post a "Chapter Update" just to say that I've decided to go ahead and turn it into a short little novel, as multiple people have suggested (although I currently still have ZERO idea how that works).

If anyone was curious, this is a link to the dance routine I imagine Catra was teaching at the start of the day:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=n40VPrRvDr4

I'm now freed up to continue writing some of the actual one-shots (which may or may not end up becoming longer, because...well...we know me). Hit up my IG or leave comments on other stuff with suggested content!

End Notes

I know I said it would be like 2-3 weeks, but then I kept imagining these scenes in my head over and over again and I just had to write them down so...there you go. Still a cliffhanger tho :) *mwah ha ha*

I AM still working on some sketches to post on my fan IG. They're gonna be cuuuuuuute.

ALSO. When other people draw stuff from this series, it makes my heart glow. It's kind of crazy to think that people actually read this and enjoy it as much as I do 😆

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!